



NAVCHETANA



NATIONAL FRAMEWORK FOR
EARLY CHILDHOOD STIMULATION 2024
FOR CHILDREN FROM BIRTH TO THREE YEARS



Navchetana

National Framework for Early Childhood Stimulation for Children from Birth to Three Years 2024

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सत्यमेव जयते

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महिला एवं बाल विकास
अल्पसंख्यक कार्य
भारत सरकार
Minister
Women & Child Development
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Message

Ensuring equitable growth for all in India's "AmritKaal" depends on the holistic development of our children. To strengthen and support the nation's youngest citizens, the Ministry of Women and Child Development is launching "Navchetana", the National Framework for Early Childhood Stimulation from birth to three years of age. The objective is to empower caregivers and Anganwadi Workers to nurture children's bodies and brains for optimal development, both within the household as well as at the Anganwadi Centre or creche.

The Ministry of Women and Child Development empowers and supports mothers and their children under three years through Mission Saksham Anganwadi and Poshan 2.0, together with the Panna and Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY) Schemes under Mission Shakti. We aim to ensure comprehensive childcare support throughout the day in a secure environment, with trained staff, educational resources, nutritional support, and activities for holistic child development. Together, these efforts will help strengthen care infrastructure, for women-led development, and set a strong foundation for the children of this country.

The National Framework for Early Childhood Stimulation aligns with the recommendations of the National Education Policy 2020 for a continuum of early learning. Encouraging caregivers to provide cognitive and physical stimulation right from gestation onwards, the framework envisions an inclusive and forward-thinking system where the optimal growth of every child is a priority. It advocates for early screenings, inclusion and referrals to identify potential challenges for Divyang children. The Stimulation Activity Calendar facilitates responsive caregiving and opportunities for early learning through month wise age based activities. Community workers and parents can utilize the framework to provide early learning to their children.

I hereby extend my warm wishes to all citizens on the launch of Navchetana, which celebrates caregivers, ensuring the dream of "Viksit Bharat" through "Har Bache Ka Vikas".

(Smriti Zubin Irani)



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Message

The Anganwadi System of the Ministry of Women and Child Development is one of the largest and most unique programmes of the Government of India. It provides early childhood care and development, operating through a widespread network of nearly 14 lakh Anganwadi Centres. The Ministry is strengthening Saksham Anganwadi and Mission Poshan 2.0, Palna and Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY) by formulating the National Framework for Early Childhood Stimulation 2024. It will seek to stimulate the sensory, social, emotional, cognitive and creative development of children from birth to 3 years.

The recommendations of the Internal Committee constituted to finalize the National Framework for Early Childhood Stimulation 2024 have been instrumental in framing guidance for Anganwadi Workers and caregivers. The framework is designed to provide the Anganwadi Worker with a basic understanding of how children grow and develop, the importance of brain development and the need for nurturing care, including responsive caregiving and opportunities for learning. In order to ensure optimal development of all children, especially for children who may not have access to these resources at home, we aim to strengthen service delivery through the Anganwadi System and Creches.

Navchetana, the National Framework for Early Childhood Stimulation aims to help children develop holistically, based on the principles of serve and return, caregivers' three acts: love, talk, play, and positive guidance. Special focus has been given for the screening, inclusion and referrals of Divyang children. The Framework provides a stepping stone for children for their long term development, aiming to ensure that all children start their learning journeys on an equal footing. Further it aims to empower Anganwadi functionaries, the world's largest women-led childcare workforce, with greater knowledge and capabilities for early childhood stimulation.

I look forward to the States and UTs taking concerted steps for implementation of Navchetana, the National Framework for Early Childhood Stimulation 2024, for children from birth to 3 years, bringing us closer to a brighter future for all.

(Anil Malik)
09/03/2024

Acronyms

Acronym	Full Form
AI & ML	Artificial Intelligence & Machine Learning
ANM	Auxiliary Nurse & Midwife
ASHA	Accredited Social Health Activist
AWW	Anganwadi Worker
CBE	Community-Based Events
CDPO	Child Development Project Officer
CMO	Chief Medical Officer
CRC	Convention on the Rights of the Child
CwD	Children with Disabilities
DIY	Do-It-Yourself
DMO	District Medical Officer
ECCE	Early Childhood Care and Education
ECCED	Early Childhood Care Education and Development
ECD	Early Childhood Development
ECS	Early Childhood Stimulation
HBNC	Home-Based Newborn Care
HBYC	Home Based Young Child Care
ICDS	Integrated Child Development Services
IEC	Information, Education and Communication
LED	Light-emitting Diode
MCP	Mother and Child Protection

MWCD	Ministry of Women and Child Development
NCF	National Curriculum Framework
NCF-FS	National Curriculum Framework - Foundational Stage
NEP	National Education Policy
NGO	Non-Governmental Organisation
NIPCCD	National Institute of Public Cooperation and Child Development
ORT	Oral Rehydration Therapy
PM	Prime Minister
PMMVY	Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana
QR	Quick Response
RO	Reverse Osmosis
RTE	Right to Education
UDID	Unique Disability Identification
UT	Union Territory
VHSND	Village Health Sanitation and Nutrition Days
WBG	World Bank Group
WCD	Women and Child Development
WHO	World Health Organisation

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Introduction

It is said that at birth, only 25% of the eventual brain is formed, while 75% develops in the first 3 years of a child's life, in the process of early childhood development (ECD). Patterns of thinking and responding are established, as at this age a baby's brain is twice as active as an adult's brain. The nurturing care framework comprises five interrelated and indivisible components: good health, adequate nutrition, safety and security, responsive caregiving and opportunities for early learning. Children require all five in order to reach their full potential.

The National Early Childhood Stimulation Framework 2024 has been prepared through the creation of an Internal Committee of experts, extensive literature review, including policy documents and latest research, and consultations with field stakeholders, like Anganwadi Workers, Supervisors, CDPOs etc. In line with the National Curriculum Framework for Foundational Stage, the framework assumes that up to 3 years of age, the child will be primarily at home unless all its caregivers are employed at work, in which case the child will have to be enrolled at a nearby creche. Therefore, a critical aspect of the first three years of child development is the support that must be provided to the caregiver in order for them to provide responsive care to the child or indulge in learning activities with them.

The present framework aims to fill the conceptual and practical gaps in the understanding and implementing care and stimulation from birth until

the first three years of a child's growth. The objective of this framework is to empower caregivers and Anganwadi Workers for holistic early stimulation, through responsive caregiving and opportunities for early learning, for optimal development of children, both body and brain. The framework guides engagement inside the home as well as at Anganwadi centres or creches, assisting caregivers in conducting stimulation activities to support and measure a child's growth and development in the first three years of life. It provides detailed information on the importance of brain development in the first three years, and step by step instructions for caregivers and frontline workers on conducting early stimulation activities. It also focuses especially on the screening, inclusion and referrals of children with disabilities.

There is a growing global consensus on promoting early childhood education in this regard and developing programs that can implement the principles. While experiences vital for optimal brain development can come sporadically at home, dedicatedly and consistently providing a child with a nurturing environment and responsive caregiving practices in this duration ensures that the children grow to their fullest in different developmental domains. This framework aims to lay out steps towards achieving this goal.

Methodology: Making of the Framework

The visionary National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and National Curriculum Framework for Foundational Stage (NCF-FS) 2022 have marked pivotal moments in recognizing the critical role of early childhood care and education in the country. The NCF-FS which covers children from age 3 to 8 years not only underscored but institutionalized the imperative for guidelines and suggested practices, specifically tailored for fostering high-quality ECCE for 3-6 years but also for the age group of 0-3 years.

“The guidelines and/or suggested practices to enable high-quality ECCE at home for the age-group of 0-3 would be developed and disseminated by the Ministry of Women and Child Development (MWCD).”

The National ECCE Policy (2013) and genesis of the ECCE Task Force by MWCD in 2022 has furthered the collaborative journey leading to the making of the National Framework for Early Childhood Stimulation (Birth to 3 years) & National Curriculum for Early Childhood Care and Education (3 to 6 years), honing in on the formative years up to the age of 6 years for child development in India. The Ministry of Women and Child Development (MWCD) assumed the lead role in developing these materials through the National Institute of Public Cooperation and Child Development (NIPCCD). NIPCCD has been an integral part in training of functionaries of Anganwadi Services Scheme under Umbrella Integrated Child Development Scheme (ICDS) since 1975. The Framework and Curriculum are infused with the latest research on ECCE, grounded in International, National and State best practices.

To ensure a nuanced and comprehensive approach, an Internal Committee, comprising representatives from Ministry of Women and Child Development (MWCD), Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW), Department of School Education and Literacy, Ministry of Education (DoSEL, MoE), National Council of Educational Research & Training (NCERT), Institute of Home Economics, Delhi University and Civil Society Organization (CSOs) was meticulously constituted. This assembly marked an inclusion of both traditional wisdom along with modern knowledge, to shape the evolving landscape of early childhood education. The first Consultation Meeting of the Internal Committee was scheduled on 19th December, 2023 at NIPCCD, New Delhi. Composition and Terms of Reference of the Internal Committee may be found at Annexure 1.

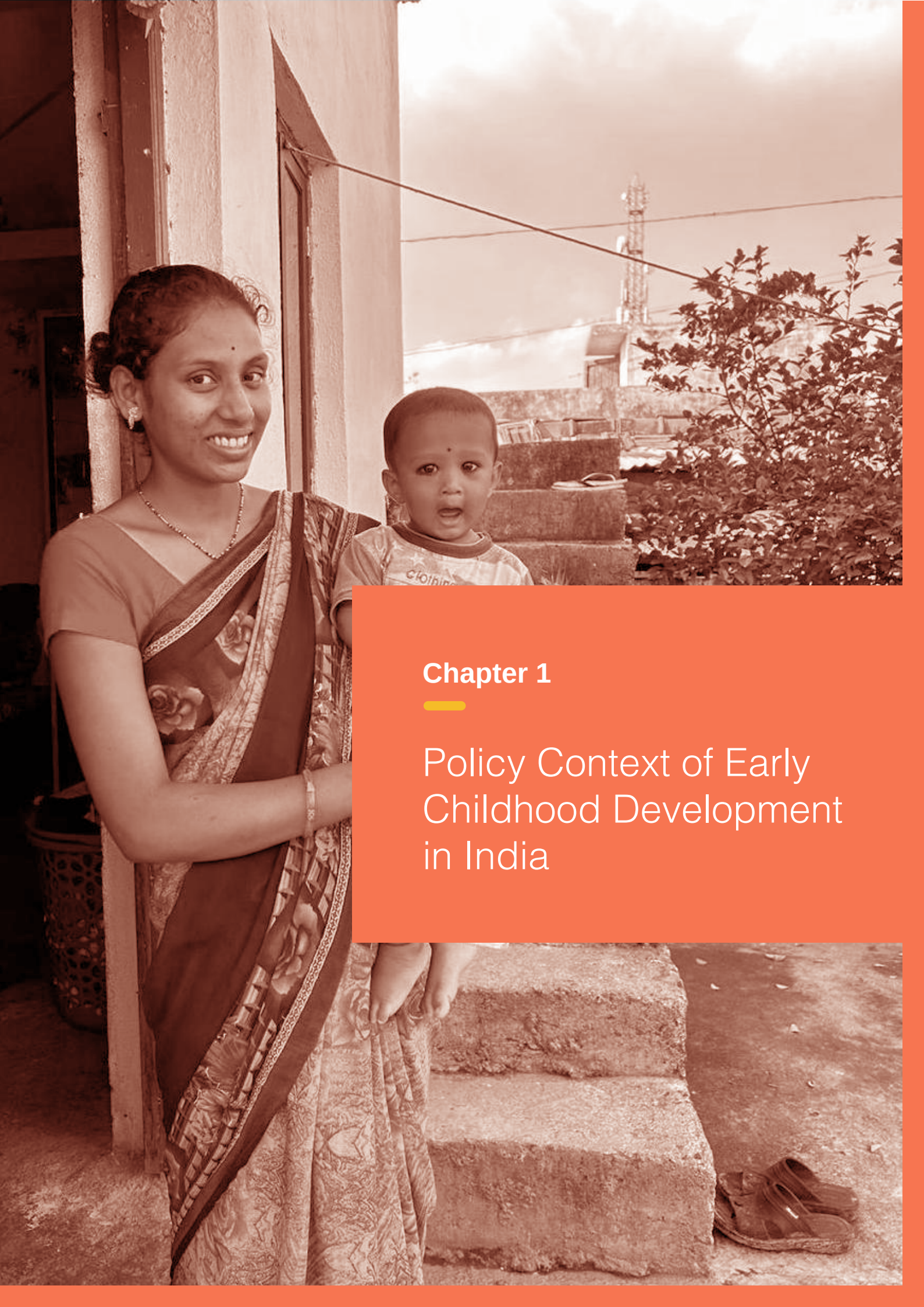
The creation of the framework was not confined to closed doors but was a participatory endeavour that resonated with the experiences and wisdom of Anganwadi Workers (AWWs). As per suggestions of the Internal Committee, NIPCCD organized a consultation with functionaries of Anganwadi System, comprising of CDPOs, Supervisors and Anganwadi Workers from Delhi on 20th December 2023. They provided indispensable insights regarding conducting ECCE and managing the children with

significant assistance from the Anganwadi Helper. Further they reiterated the need for a framework for stimulation from birth to three years, including guidelines by caregivers during home visits. The valuable inputs from the field level functionaries, along with Guidelines of Saksham Anganwadi/ Mission Poshan 2.0, Standard Operating Procedures of the Palna Scheme and report of MWCD's ECCE Task Force steered the Framework in a dynamic and responsive way, attuned to the practical needs and preferences of those directly engaged in early childhood care.

The Framework for Stimulation (0-3 years) therefore aims to fill the conceptual and practical gaps in the understanding and implementing care and stimulation from birth until the first three years of a child's growth. The framework guides engagement inside the home as well as at Anganwadi centres or creches, assisting caregivers in conducting stimulation activities to support and measure a child's growth and development in the first three years of life. It provides detailed information on the importance of brain development in the first three years, and step by step instructions for caregivers and frontline workers on conducting early stimulation activities. The use of indigenous toys and low cost / no cost materials has also been emphasized.

Special Inputs were sought with regard to practices for Inclusion of Divyang Children. The Framework builds on the Anganwadi Protocol for Divyang Children, 2023 released by MWCD. In order to facilitate inclusion of children with disabilities, an age-appropriate screening tool that can be easily administered by Anganwadi Workers has been included, which has been finalized in consultation with DEPwD.

The Framework, informed by the latest research and best practices, aspires not just to meet existing standards but to set a new benchmark for early stimulation. This approach seamlessly integrates the dynamic educational landscape for children aged 0-6, setting the stage for a new era in early childhood development in India.

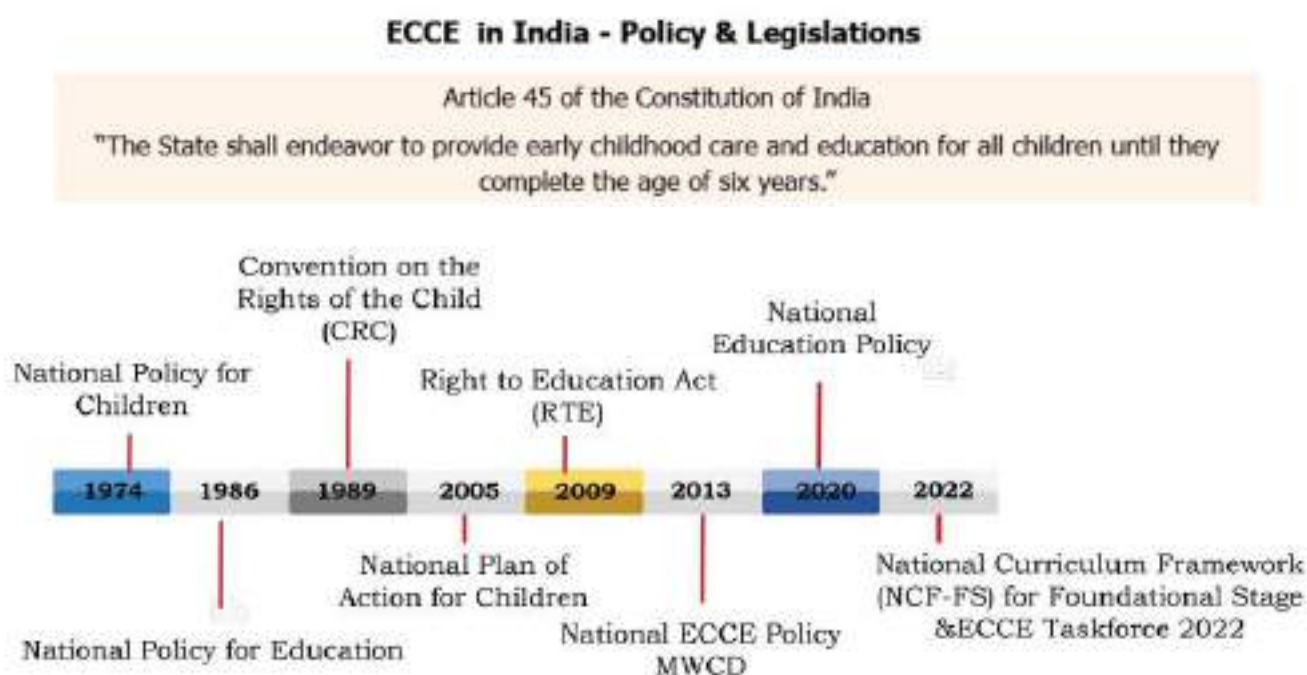


Chapter 1

Policy Context of Early Childhood Development in India

1.1 Policy Context

India has a robust history of policy frameworks dealing with child development, originating from Article 45 of the Constitution of India. These include the National Policy for Children (1974), National Policy for Education (1986), National Plan of Action for Children (2005), National Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) Policy (2013), and the Maternity Benefit Amendment Act (2017), which provides for maternity leave up to 26 weeks and crèche facilities in all establishments. India is also a signatory to the International Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) 1989. Further, by 2030, Sustainable Development Goal 4 aspires to guarantee that all girls and boys have access to high-quality early childhood development, care, and pre-primary education.



The National ECCE Policy 2013 emphasises the “need to ensure Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) for every child below six years across the country.” It also laid out 11 non-negotiable standards for the quality of early childhood education provided at the Anganwadi Centre, including 4 hours of instruction, classroom measurements, adequate outdoor space, training, age and developmentally appropriate child-centric curriculum transacted in the mother tongue or public local vernacular, and other infrastructure. Based on this, the National ECCE Curriculum 2014 also took an integrated approach from 0 to 6 years, providing a focus on care and stimulation, together with suggested developmentally appropriate practices for children from birth to three years.

The ECCE Task Force constituted by the Ministry of Women and Child Development in 2022

recommended two parallel sets of IEC strategies to be implemented for children aged 0 to 3 years: a home-based caregiver education program delivered by Anganwadi workers and ASHA workers through structured home visits, and a wider community outreach campaign. There is a need to develop detailed material to support early stimulation during these home visits.

Further, recognizing the criticality of early screening and intervention in the identification and prevention of disabilities, the Ministry of Women and Child Development launched the Anganwadi Protocol for Divyang Children in 2023, covering screening, inclusion, and referrals of Divyang Children, including those under the age of three years. Further expansion of a screening schedule and activity instructions for inclusion are required.

Children with developmental delays, disabilities or who are malnourished may require additional support to develop optimally. While caregivers are often able to recognize when a child is slow in achieving the developmental milestones compared to other children in their families and communities, they need support to plan and implement appropriate stimulation activities for their child. Caregivers may not always feed or communicate with these children as frequently as needed, and it is important that they are aware of the special needs of these children and their capacities.

- *ECCE Training Module for Anganwadi Workers, 2017, pp. 14*

Finally, the overarching National Education Policy (NEP) in 2020 stressed the need for appropriate stimulation in the early years of a child's growth, recognizing that adequate care is necessary to build a strong foundation for life. It suggests that the overall aims of Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) are to attain optimal outcomes in the domains of physical and motor development, cognitive development, socio-emotional-ethical development, cultural/artistic development, and the development of communication and early language, literacy, and numeracy.

In line with this focus, the NEP had envisaged a dedicated framework for 0-3 year-olds, aligned with the above principles, the latest research on ECCE, and national and international best practices. The National Curriculum Framework for Foundational Stage (NCF-FS), released in 2022 and covering children from age 3 to 8 years, states in section 1.1.2 that

“The guidelines and/or suggested practices to enable high-quality ECCE at home for the age-group of 0-3 would be developed and

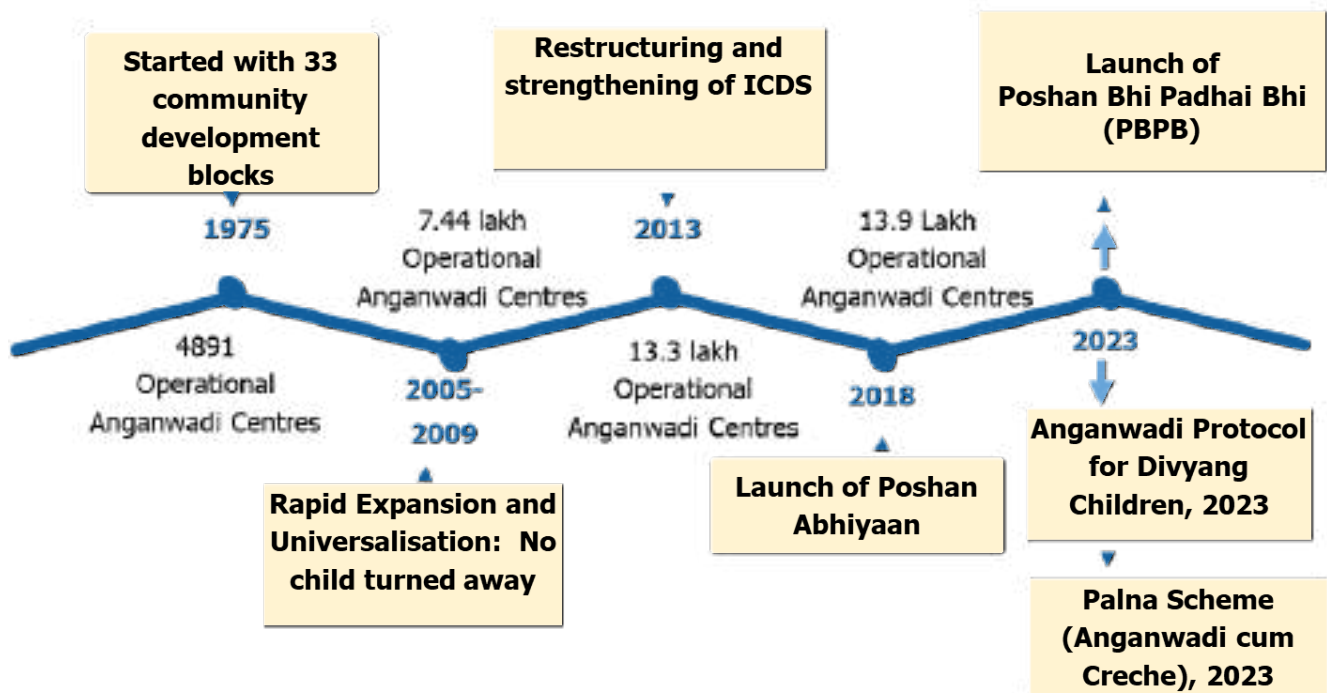
disseminated by the Ministry of Women and Child Development (MWCD).”

Noting the ubiquity of home as the space where a child grows and learns from birth till three, NCF-FS had underlined the need to go beyond providing health and nutritional care to the rapidly growing infant. It stressed providing well-rounded care to the child in these early years, focussing specifically on the cognitive and emotional stimulation of the infant through “talking, playing, moving, listening to music and sounds, and stimulation of all the other senses, particularly sight and touch in order to reach expected developmental milestones across domains, and develop “early language, and emergent literacy and numeracy.” NCF-FS considered that families may also send their children to creches and that creche workers must adopt similar practices and attitudes wherever applicable. All the recommendations of NCF-FS followed the recognition of the vitality of early years in a child's life by the NEP, highlighting the need to ensure quality early childhood care and education to all.

1.2 Programme Context

In 1975, the Integrated Child Development Services was launched to provide integrated care, including supplementary nutrition and nonformal preschool education to children under the age of 6 years. Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) was included in the policy framework in 1986. The scheme was universalized in 2007-2008, ensuring no child in need is turned away. In 2013, it was restructured via the ICDS Mission: Broad Framework for Implementation to place greater emphasis on Early Childhood Care Education and Development (ECCED), i.e., including children under 3. It was envisioned to convert Anganwadi centres into vibrant Early Childhood Education Centres, with a particular focus on children under three years of age.

Anganwadi System (1975-2024)



ASHA workers also conduct extensive home visitation under the Home-Based Newborn Care (HBNC) and Home-Based Young Child Care (HBYC) programs. However, guidance materials, such as the Home Visit Form (Examination of Mother and Newborn) for ASHA and Anganwadi workers, are primarily focused on the health of the mother and the child, including lactation, bleeding, sepsis, etc. Recognizing this, the ECCE Task Force constituted by the Ministry of Women and Child Development

recommended joint visits and training for Anganwadi and ASHA workers to improve the intensity and quality of home visits to include early stimulation. The ECCE Training Module for Anganwadi Workers, released in 2017, briefly mentions activities that can be undertaken and an approach for counselling parents. The guidance provided regarding early stimulation or opportunities for early learning, checks for developmental delays, and early screening of disabilities must be strengthened.

Counselling caregivers on conducting stimulation activities

Most families try to do their best for their children. Their efforts must be praised and they should be empowered to continue early stimulation in home settings. They may not know that play and interaction are essential to promote the optimal development of their child. They should be counselled to:

- Get the child's attention
- Communicate with their child, respond to their child
- Introduce play activities gradually, in a sensitive and responsive manner,
- Selecting activities that are appropriate for the age and skills of their child
- Follow the child's lead during the activities
- Help the child with a new task, and praise the child for her efforts
- ECCE Training Module for Anganwadi Workers, 2017, pp. 13

MWCD has addressed children under three years of age through the erstwhile National Creche Scheme, which, unlike the Anganwadi system, is not universal. The new Palna scheme envisions creches with age-appropriate developmental activities, including tracking developmental milestones, and low-cost and no-cost teaching-learning materials and toys, which are culturally embedded and environment-friendly. The Standard Operating Procedure (2023) for the Palna scheme (Anganwadi-cum-Creche), Mission Shakti, contains detailed guidelines for whole daycare, additional workers and helpers, materials, nutritional support, and co-curricular activities.

Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY) also supports caregivers from a health, nutrition, and behavioural-change lens by providing its second tranche of cash transfer based on full immunisation of the child up to the age of 14 weeks, i.e., close to 3 months. It also encourages the use of the Mother and Child Protection Card (MCP) for counselling young mothers with age-linked activities and instructions, including red flags or warning signs for developmental delays.

Finally, in 2023, the Ministry of Women and Child launched Poshan Bhi Padhai Bhi, under Saksham Anganwadi and Mission Poshan 2.0, aiming to enhance early childhood care and education (ECCE) in the Anganwadi system. It envisions high-quality infrastructure, play equipment, and well-trained Anganwadi workers. The initiative focuses on early stimulation for 0-3-year-olds and ECCE for 3-6-

year-olds, including Divyang children. A two-tier training model is being implemented through the National Institute of Public Cooperation and Child Development (NIPCCD), with 3 days of training for Anganwadi workers including training modules regarding stimulation of children from the ages of 0 to 3 years, including activities to be conducted with caregivers at home, in the centre and the community.

“The Mother and Child Protection card is a tool to support parents and caregivers in promoting the essential elements of stimulation, health, nutrition and protection. It draws from evidence in neuroscience on the importance of stimulation, nutrition and protection of children, including children with disabilities, for their optimal development. It provides information on immunization, complementary and responsive feeding and early stimulation to parents and caregivers. Anganwadi Workers can use the card to explain a child’s progress and to inform parents about the age-appropriate developmental milestones, their significance and how these can be promoted through early stimulation activities.

- ECCE Training Module for Anganwadi Workers, 2017, pp. 12

1.3 States practices for children from birth to 3 years

- Women and Child Development Departments of different State governments have taken various initiatives to advance children’s cognitive stimulation from birth to three years.
- For example, under the Aama Kuni Pila scheme, Odisha conducts various activities, including sensitization and capacity building of caregivers, monthly ECCE days, and community-based creches.
- Maharashtra is running a program called ‘Aarambh’ for 0-3-year-old children, wherein the activities include home visits, parent meetings at Anganwadi centers, and community events to promote ECD. Their accompanying ‘Ankur’ module focuses on parenting guidance.
- Similarly, Meghalaya’s Early Childhood Development Mission coaches parents through regular home visits about home-based young child care (0 to 1.5 years), positive parenting, and healthy diets.
- Other states, including Punjab, Telangana, Daman and Diu are conducting digital interventions and

disseminating video content to promote early stimulation and empower families.

- States of Odisha, Haryana, Tamil Nadu, and Karnataka also provide expanded creche services for 0-3-year-old children.
- Assam offers a 6-month certificate course on ECCE for Anganwadi Workers for birth to 6 years of child development, in convergence with the State Council for Education Research and Training. The 'Ghare Ghare Anganwadi' program focuses on responsive parenting, using low and no-cost material.





Chapter 2

Need and Importance of Early Childhood Stimulation

The Early Childhood Stimulation begins from the biological and sensory growth of the child right from their gestation in the mother's womb. Research has shown that the foetus develops the abilities to hear, taste, smell, process information, sense pain, pressure and temperature as it grows. The senses of smell and taste develop faster than that of hearing or vision, giving rise to the preferences and aversion to a particular taste or odour and more importantly, the hearing experience of the baby in the womb comes to determine the post birth language development. While the specific details of the sound may not reach the foetus, the melody of rhythm of what is said around them during pregnancy is used by the newborn to discriminate their native language from others when they come across it first—it is likely that the baby would respond easily to the native language he/she may have received from her mother during pregnancy.



“Garbh Sanskar”- following meaningful practices to stimulate, educate and make the child healthy from the time of its conception.

The mother and child grow together during pregnancy, either forming a new biological and emotional selves in response to the changes in the other. It is important, therefore, for a mother to ensure a healthy, nutritious lifestyle in that period, to both facilitate the growth of the baby in the womb, and keep herself free from any kinds of distress or health-related difficulties. Provided the daunting nature of changes a mother might experience in this course, they must also be aided by their family members in caring for themselves, and the growing baby. Creating such a healthy, stimulating and supportive environment around the mother ensures that the newborn experiences the world in the most conducive manner possible.



Effective ways to Manage Mental Health during Pregnancy and Postpartum

Only 25% of the brain is formed at birth, while 75% develops in the first three years of a child's life during early childhood development (ECD). At this age, a baby's brain is twice as active as an adult's, enabling it to establish essential patterns of thinking and responding. New synaptic connections (synapses help a child develop vital sensory capacities) develop in response to stimulation, forming the bedrock of a child's development across different domains in the first three years of life. The Lancet series on ECD in 2007, 2011, and 2017 has provided a plethora of scientific evidence to support the importance of ECD, and the Nurturing Care Framework has evolved to channel this science into action. (Chattopadhyay and Aneja, 2021).

The Most Important Things

Every single child is born with a brain that can develop and grow. Although all children do not develop at a similar speed and in a similar manner, each of their brains is capable of forming new connections through the right kind of care and stimulation.

- It does not matter whether the child is male or female
- It does not matter whether the child is fair or dark skinned
- It does not matter whether the child is tall, short, is thin built or chubby
- It does not matter in which community or in which part of the world the child was born

So we should be happy as long as the child is 'healthy and disease free'. However, what matters most is the brain development of the child. The potential of the brain to develop in the child does not differ in a boy or girl, dark skinned or fair skinned for the brain has no colour. It is the developed brain which can transform the family, society, country and the world at large.

- Journey of the First 1000 Days, MoHFW, pp 81

2.1 What is Early Childhood Stimulation?

Stimulation activities involve intentional efforts to activate the child's early development. It is more than a series of exercises; it is a continuous dialogue between the child and those who are for the child. The child's development occurs as a result of an interaction between maturation and learning. Development that occurs due to maturation is when what is potentially present in the organism unfolds. For example, children's motor and coordination skills develop as they grow. Similarly, cognitive skills such as information processing, language development, and memory also develop with age. This kind of maturation occurs in fixed sequences and is essential for learning. However, the child needs practice and guidance to learn specific skills such as reading and speaking with confidence, solving puzzles, and self-regulation. For instance, a child whose caregivers

read and speak to her regularly will likely learn more words than a child whose caregivers do not.



2.2 Objectives of Early Childhood Stimulation (ECS)

The first three years of an individual's life impact their health and ability through life. With this in mind, the main objective of Early Childhood Stimulation (ECS) activities is to provide the child with opportunities to achieve the optimum level of development during this critical period. The specific objectives of Early Childhood Stimulation is to:

- Ensure the healthy development of the child through breastfeeding, immunisation, ORT, weaning foods, low-cost nutritious food, and growth monitoring;
- Develop trust and emotional security in the child by making them feel loved, valued, safe, and guided by letting them know that they are wanted and can bank on the adult's help if anything goes wrong.
- Stimulate the child's intellectual curiosity and help

them understand the world in which they live by creating opportunities to explore, manipulate, and experiment.

- Enhance the child's language development by talking, reading, and singing to them regularly and allowing them to express themselves through gestures and words.
- Develop adequate muscular coordination, basic motor skills, and personal hygiene habits in the child.
- Develop social awareness in the child, making them sensitive to their own needs and those of others and capable of adjusting to the demands of the social context.
- Develop fundamental values of sympathy, tolerance, kindness, and respect.

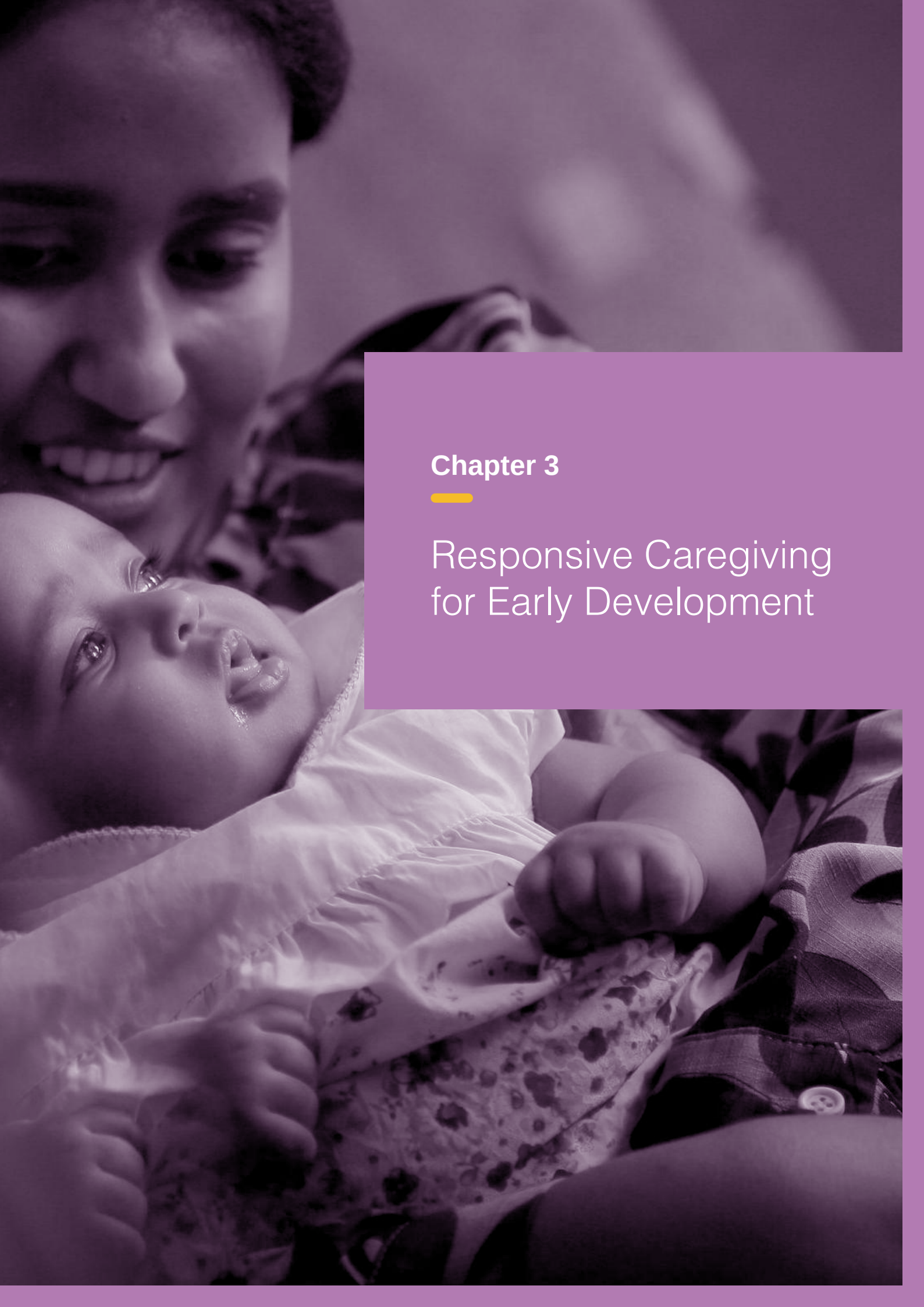
2.3 The Nurturing Care Framework

The Nurturing Care Framework comprises five interrelated and indivisible components: good health, adequate nutrition, safety and security, responsive caregiving, and opportunities for early learning. Children require all five in order to reach their full potential. The seeds of different social, emotional, and cognitive behaviours and skills that may come into effect or use later in life are sown in the first three years as the brain absorbs and imbibes what the child experiences. The literature further states that the major developmental task of infants and very young children is the formation of an attachment bond with a caregiver/s who is reliable and responsive to the child's emotional and physical needs" (McLean, 2016). Given the complete reliance of babies on their caregivers for survival, physical needs, and emotional comfort, caregiver behaviour is a critical factor in early childhood development. Predictable, consistent, and responsive care is the key to secure attachment.

This document focuses on two of the five components of the nurturing care framework: 'responsive caregiving' and 'creating opportunities for early learning.'



Source: WHO and WBG. 2018b

A close-up photograph of a woman with dark hair smiling warmly at a baby. The baby is lying down, looking up at the woman. The image is overlaid with a semi-transparent purple rectangle containing the chapter title.

Chapter 3

Responsive Caregiving for Early Development

While caring for an infant is instinctive for most caregivers, especially for its parents, using a sound method can ensure that their care drives the child's growth and development in the early years while protecting the child and making them feel loved. Research on early childhood stimulation has proven the efficacy of 'responsive caregiving' as a sound caregiving approach that fosters the child's socio-emotional, language, cognitive, and motor development.



Socio-Emotional

Helps develop a secure attachment style in later years, allowing the child to be more socially competent with peers and other adults



Cognitive

Children of responsive caregivers can learn about new things in their environment by looking at them



Language

Children of responsive caregivers are known to speak their first word and first sentence as many as six months earlier than those who don't receive responsive caregiving



Motor

Responsive caregiving practices can speed postural control and the cascade of new motor skills that follow

Responsive caregiving refers to the ability of caregivers to notice, understand, and respond to a child's signals promptly and appropriately. In their first three years, a child's brain develops through their experiences, in that the brain is both 'experience-expectant' and 'experience-dependent.' Experiences that follow a responsive caregiving method lead to a child's required motor and sensory stimulation, leading to new synaptic connections. This process forms the bedrock of a child's development across different domains in the first three years of life.

Although Responsive caregiving often includes aspects of responsive feeding, this chapter will focus on the pedagogical approaches and behaviours to be adopted by the caregiver to enable early childhood stimulation: Serve and Return, The Caregiver's Three Acts: Love, Talk, Play, and Positive Guidance.



3.1 Serve and Return

SERVE AND RETURN

STEP 1

Observe the Serve

The baby serves by picking up the ball and shaking it. The caregiver observes this serve which helps her understand the baby better.



STEP 2

Respond to the Serve

The caregiver responds to the serve by pointing at the ball and sharing or acknowledging the baby's interest.



STEP 3

Give it a name

The caregiver gives it a name so that baby can learn the relationship between the object or action and its name.



STEP 4

Take turns

The caregiver then waits patiently for the child to respond. They go back and forth lovingly fostering independence and confidence in the baby.



STEP 5

Transition

The baby drops the ball, she now wants to put her foot in her mouth. Caregiver responds and the back and forth continues enabling more serve and return interactions.



3.2 Love, Talk, Play

CAREGIVER'S THREE ACTS



LOVE

- Make eye contact with the baby
- Smile at the baby
- Hug, kiss, caress and cuddle baby
- Hold the baby close to your body



TALK

- Imitate the baby's babbling sounds
- Describe and name the baby's gestures and activities
- Talk to the baby about common objects or activities
- Sing to the baby



PLAY

- Play with the baby
- Provide them with play materials that stimulate their minds and senses
- Participate in the child's imaginative play
- Have fun with the baby

Chapter 4

Creating Opportunities for Early Learning through Month-wise Activities



This chapter will cover the child's environment, play material, gender-responsive interactions, safe and secure environment, and 36 sets of activities from month 0 to month 36 of the child's age, i.e., month-wise, from birth to three years. The activities cover holistic stimulation for the child's cognitive, socio-emotional, language, physical, and creative development.

4.1 Creating a Suitable Environment for Early Stimulation

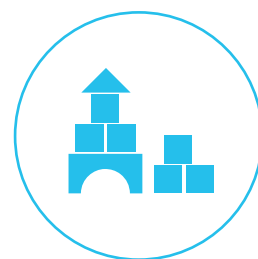
a. Play Material

Play materials help the parent engage with the child in diverse ways, increasing sensory stimulation and the resultant quality of play. These play materials do not always need to be store-bought. Objects and materials found readily in the home or natural environment can also be used. The caregiver can also prepare Do-It-Yourself (DIY) toys using household or waste materials such as cups, bottles, and leftover pieces of fabric, making them sustainable and reducing environmental impact. Indigenous and culturally embedded toys are also helpful in promoting cultural awareness.



b. Stimulation Activities

In the earliest years, children learn through diverse experiences that align with their developmental needs. The following section outlines a monthly stimulation activity calendar to support caregivers in this journey. Although the recommended activities provided are classified according to the child's age, caregivers can and should adapt them to meet the abilities of the child in question: say, if a child is already able to do the activity prescribed for their age, a caregiver can increase the difficulty levels. Conversely, a caregiver can lower the difficulty level if a child cannot do an activity prescribed for their age bracket. Lastly, it is essential to note that the activities and materials laid out in the upcoming section are suggested with the general Indian context in mind. They can and should be adapted and modified to suit various social and cultural contexts. Parents should, however, consciously incorporate stimulation activities into the child's daily routine.



c. Ensuring Safety and Security

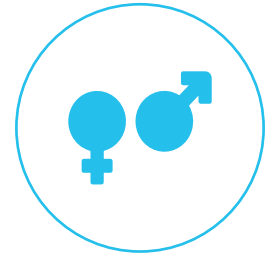
At a young age, the infant or toddler depends entirely on the caregiver for their physical and emotional security. Therefore, The caregiver should follow certain best practices to keep the child from harm. The child's play area should be made safe by ensuring all materials are nontoxic and nonhazardous. They should be supervised and guarded



from physical injury caused by falling from a height or dropping heavy objects. The child's emotional environment should also be made as stress-free as possible through respectful, caring, and non-violent interactions with and among all other persons.

d. Gender Responsive Interactions

During the early years, children learn from their environment and the actions of their caregivers. As they grow, they observe and form conclusions about what it means to be a boy or a girl. It is, therefore, critical to ensure that children of both genders have equal opportunities to grow and develop. Caregivers should become aware of their own gender biases and avoid statements and actions that might impose limitations on their learning. Examples of bias include assuming that girls are physically or emotionally weaker than boys, providing girls with toys such as dolls and kitchen sets while purchasing cars for boys, and praising boys for being 'brave' and girls for being 'pretty'.



e. Positive Guidance while Dealing with Challenging Situations

Caregivers can sometimes find children's behaviours challenging. For example, infants may fuss or cry despite the adults' efforts to comfort them. Sometimes, they may hit, bite, fall to the floor, cry, kick, whine, or say "no." In such situations, caregivers need to understand the reason behind the child's behaviour; is the child hungry, sleepy, or neglected? Doing so will enable the caregiver to respond appropriately to soothe the child. Gently modelling the 'right' behaviour and appreciating a child when they demonstrate the correct behaviour can help them self-regulate and deal with uncomfortable emotions or situations.





Stimulation Activity Calendar

**National Framework for
Early Childhood Stimulation**

For children from birth to three years

Activity: Eating Healthy

Steps:

1. During the pregnancy period, the family members can make sure that the mother is provided with healthy and nutritious food.
2. She should also be sufficiently hydrated.
3. She should be provided with the necessary dietary supplements to enable her to have a successful pregnancy and childbirth.

Value of Activity: This will help mother and child become healthy and strong.



Activity: Physical Activity and Exercise

Steps:

1. The pregnant mother should be encouraged to do regular physical exercise such as walking, simple yoga, etc.
2. Household chores and responsibilities should be carefully organized to ensure that the pregnant mother does not have to perform heavy work and is provided with sufficient time for rest.

Value of Activity: This will boost mental and physical well-being for mother and child.



DURING PREGNANCY

Activity: Create a positive and calming environment

Steps:

1. Reduce all kinds of stress for the mother by supporting, caring and loving her.
2. Encourage the mother to take up calming hobbies such as painting, stitching, or other arts and crafts.
3. Listen to soothing music and practice meditation.

Value of Activity: A child in the womb will develop better if the mother is feeling stress-free, positive and calm.



Activity: Communicate with the child

Steps:

1. Mother and father should be encouraged to have positive conversations with their unborn child.
2. Mother can tell them about their daily activities, narrate stories, sing them songs in a soothing voice.

Value of activity: All of this will encourage the fetus' mental and emotional stimulation and will support their secure development.



Discovering Loving Faces

Steps:

1. While looking at the baby, smile, and see if baby smiles back.
2. Open and close your mouth, making soft sounds for them.
3. Hold baby's hands and gently guide them over your face.
4. Let baby hold your nose and have fun!

Value of activity:

Enhances visual engagement, promotes facial recognition, and fosters tactile exploration, strengthening the bond between baby and caregiver.



Imitating Sounds

Steps:

1. Sit with the baby and listen to the sounds they make.
2. When baby makes a sound, repeat it back to them.
3. Encourage baby to make the sound again.
4. Smile and express joy, showing that you appreciate baby's sounds - "Baby can talk!"

Value of activity:

Builds a secure attachment, promotes emotional regulation, and provides comfort through responsive caregiving.



0-3 MONTHS



Singing to Baby

Steps:

1. Choose any song or lullaby and sing it softly to your baby.
2. Use a soothing voice and look at your baby while you sing.
3. Watch for baby's reactions, noting what they enjoy about the singing.
4. Enjoy this bonding moment through shared melodies and repeat whenever you have time!

Value of activity:

Singing promotes language development, emotional connection, and a sense of security.



Loving and Hugging

Steps:

1. Hold your baby close for a cozy, safe hug.
2. Rock and cuddle your baby gently and give them small affectionate kisses.
3. Softly tell your baby you love them to make them feel secure.
4. Cuddle often, just to show your love at any time!

Value of activity:

Singing promotes language development, emotional connection, and a sense of security.



Follow the Bee

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Imagine your finger is a bee and gently place your buzzing finger in front of baby's face.
2. Move it around, inviting baby to follow the "bee."
3. Playfully land the "bee" on baby's nose, giggling together.
4. Share laughter and enjoy the delightful game.

Value of activity: Enhances visual tracking skills, hand-eye coordination, and creates a joyful bonding experience.



Reaching for Objects

Materials: Baby's favorite toy or object

Steps:

1. Show the baby a beloved toy and get them excited
2. Dangle it in front, encouraging them to reach out for it
3. Guide the baby to touch the object
4. Praise the baby with joy when they reach out to the object

Value of activity: Develops reaching skills, hand-eye coordination, and builds confidence through positive reinforcement.



4 MONTHS

Imitating Sounds

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Spend time with the baby and listen to the sounds they make.
2. When the baby makes a sound, repeat it back to them.
3. Encourage the baby to make the sound again.
4. Smile and express joy, showing that you appreciate their sounds - "Baby can talk!"

Value of activity: Fosters communication, strengthens the caregiver-baby connection, and encourages baby's vocalization development in a playful manner.



Talking with Baby

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Face the baby and make a new sound.
2. Wait and see if the baby repeats or makes any sound.
3. Respond to the baby and patiently wait for another sound.
4. Enjoy this back-and-forth and soon you will have a conversation with your little one!

Value of activity: Boosts language development, encourages communication, and creates an interactive and engaging conversation between caregiver and baby.



Dress-Up Fun

Materials: Baby's shirt, top or other clothes

Steps:

1. When putting the shirt or dress over baby's head, say, "Where is baby?"
2. Pull the shirt down and cheer, "Oo! There he/she is!"
3. Smile and share laughter with your baby!

Value of activity:

Enhances sensory experience, fosters language development, and creates a joyful dressing routine



Taking a Walk Together

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Take a walk around the house or outside the house with baby.
2. Point out different things and people, naming them.
3. Share simple stories or descriptions during the walk.
4. Enjoy a delightful walk and talk with baby!

Value of activity:

Enhances language development, introduces vocabulary, and creates a stimulating and interactive environment during a walk.



5 MONTHS

Fingers and Toes

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Play with baby, engaging their attention.
2. Move each toe and finger separately
3. Sing a cheerful rhyme about fingers and toes 'little finger, ring finger, middle finger, pointer finger, thumb!'
4. Watch baby laugh and enjoy the delightful fun!

Value of activity:

Enhances body awareness, promotes motor development, and creates a joyous and interactive playtime experience.



Gripping Fingers

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Place one of your fingers in the middle of the baby's hand.
2. Encourage the baby to grasp your finger gently.
3. Slowly pull your finger back and see if the baby holds on.
4. Praise and celebrate the baby's achievement of holding on!

Value of activity:

Strengthens fine motor skills, promotes hand-eye coordination, and creates a positive environment for developing a baby's grip.



Soft Words with Baby

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Engage with your child using soft and gentle words.
2. Pay attention to their "baby talks," gestures, and sounds.
3. Respond sensitively to create a dialogue with your baby.
4. Enjoy the connection formed through caring communication!

Value of activity: Enhances sensitivity and responsiveness, strengthens the caregiver-child bond, and promotes a nurturing and supportive environment.



Sing a song together

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Choose a favorite song or a lullaby for the baby.
2. Gently sing the chosen tune, making eye contact with the baby.
3. Embrace the joy of singing, and don't be shy about your voice.
4. Observe the baby's reactions and respond with warmth and smiles.
5. Enjoy this special bonding time through the magic of music.

Value of activity: Cultivates language development, emotional connection, and auditory recognition.



6 MONTHS

Cheek Balloons

Materials: None

Steps:

1. After changing your child's clothes, puff up your cheeks like a balloon.
2. Place your child's feet on your cheeks to make a "phat" sound.
3. Make various sounds and funny faces to captivate your child's attention.
4. Enjoy the laughter and engagement with your child.

Value of activity: Develops visual tracking, fosters responsiveness, and strengthens communication skills.



Swinging Time

Materials: Soft cloth or blanket

Steps:

1. Create a gentle swing using a soft cloth at home.
2. Place the baby in the improvised cradle with a secure knot.
3. Lovingly swing the baby from side to side with soothing motions.
4. Share smiles and laughter with the baby throughout the activity.
5. Ensure a comfortable and secure experience for the baby.

Value of activity: Fosters a sense of security, promotes bonding, and enhances the baby's sense of balance.



Peek-a-Boo with Baby

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Cover your face with hands, saying, "Where is Mommy?"
2. Open hands and joyfully exclaim, "Boo! Here I am!"
3. Share laughter with baby as she discovers you each time.

Value of activity:

Encourages visual tracking, fosters a sense of object permanence, and creates a delightful bonding experience through peek-a-boo play.



Reaching out to the ball

Materials: Soft, lightweight ball

Steps:

1. Place the baby on their belly or back with a soft ball nearby.
2. Gently move the ball from left to right, just within reach.
3. Encourage the baby to reach out for the ball with excitement.
4. Cheer and celebrate even small attempts to touch or grab the ball.
5. Repeat the movement, creating a playful and engaging activity.

Value of activity:

Enhances gross motor skills, encourages grasping movements, and improves hand-eye coordination.



7 MONTHS

Lip Movements

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Copy the sounds made by your child while dressing, like "Aa, S, ee, S, S, ooo, S, bee, S, S."
2. Observe how your child responds to the imitation, encourage them to repeat!
3. Place your child's fingers on your lips, letting them feel the movements and vibrations.
4. Explore various sounds together for a playful and interactive experience.

Value of activity:

Enhances sensory awareness, promotes language understanding, and strengthens the relationship between caregiver and child.



Bath Time Fun

Materials: Plastic container or cup, water

Steps:

1. Show baby how to splash water gently during bath time.
2. Fill the container, saying "full," then pour, saying "empty."
3. Repeat and encourage baby to try with your assistance.
4. Have a joyful time together, celebrating each splash!

Value of activity:

Bath time becomes a playful learning experience, teaching concepts of fullness, emptiness, and enhancing sensory exploration.



Locating the Sound

Materials: Household items that make a sound (e.g., plate, cup, bowl, etc.)

Steps:

1. Play with your child using a household item that makes a sound, such as a plate.
2. Move around, banging a plate softly, and observe your child's reactions.
3. Notice if the child moves their head to follow the sound; try to get their attention!
4. Smile and praise to the child when they figure out where the sound is coming from.

Value of activity:

Enhances auditory tracking skills, encourages observation, and fosters communication through joyful interaction.



8 MONTHS

Repeating New Sounds

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Face baby, make eye contact, and smile.
2. Introduce a new sound that baby doesn't know yet.
3. Repeat the new sound slowly several times for the baby.
4. Encourage baby to imitate and repeat the sound; praise them plenty when they do it!

Value of activity:

Boosts language development, promotes imitation, and creates a fun and interactive learning experience for the baby.



Spinning Bangles

Materials: Thick plastic or metal bangle

Steps:

1. Sit with the baby and hold the thick bangle in front of them.
2. Spin the bangle gently, creating a captivating visual effect.
3. Encourage the baby to reach out for the spinning bangle.
4. Praise the baby enthusiastically for their reaching efforts.
5. Repeat the spinning motion, making it a joyful and interactive experience.

Value of activity:

Enhances hand-eye coordination, visual tracking, and reaching skills.



Dress-Up Conversation

Materials: Baby's clothes

Steps:

1. Talk to baby while you are dressing them, mentioning each item, e.g., "Let's put on your shirt."
2. Name body parts during dressing, saying, "Hold up your arm."
3. Play finger and toe games, such as "This little piggy," for added fun!

Value of activity:

Enhances language development, introduces body parts, and creates an enjoyable and interactive dressing routine for the baby.



Dropping is Fun!

Materials: Safe object (e.g., ball, crumpled paper)

Steps:

1. Give your child a safe object to hold and drop, like a ball or crumpled paper.
2. Allow the child to drop the object, saying, "Down it falls and up it comes."
3. Encourage the child to repeat the action and play with different objects.

Value of Activity:

Develops hand-eye coordination, introduces cause and effect, and creates an entertaining and interactive playtime.



9 MONTHS

Action Words and Action Sounds

Materials: Safe object (e.g., rattle)

Steps:

1. Sit with your child with any safe object, then encourage your child to shake, slam, or twirl it.
2. Observe and talk to the child about their exploration, e.g., "You shook the rattle and made a sound."
3. Create action words and sounds to describe the child's play, like "Chhuk... Chhuk... Chhuk... Chhuk," encourage child to repeat!

Value of Activity:

Enhances sensory exploration and encourages language development



Roll and Reach

Materials: Small clear plastic bottle; water; shiny paper (optional)

Steps:

1. Clean a small, clear plastic bottle and half-fill it with water.
2. Optionally, add small pieces of shiny paper and close tightly.
3. Roll the bottle away from the baby.
4. Encourage the baby to move forward and reach the bottle.
5. Praise the baby when they successfully reach the bottle.

Value of Activity:

Promotes crawling and reaching skills and enhances gross motor development



Mealtime Conversations

Materials: Baby's food

Steps:

1. Talk to the baby during feeding, discussing the foods they are eating.
2. Smile and respond to the baby's cues, especially when they show they want more.
3. Encourage baby to interact and make mealtime a happy and positive interaction!

Value of Activity:

Enhances language development, promotes positive associations with food, and strengthens the caregiver-child bond



In and Out

Materials: Clear plastic box or bottle, small safe objects

Steps:

1. Provide a clear plastic box or bottle and small, safe objects that the baby can hold.
2. Show the baby how to put objects into the bottle, saying "In."
3. Assist the baby in placing an object inside while emphasizing "In."
4. Help the baby shake the object out, saying "Out."
5. Praise the baby when they successfully put an object in!

Value of activity:

Enhances fine motor skills and promotes hand-eye coordination



10 MONTHS

Open the Knot

Materials: Soft handkerchief

Steps:

1. Tie a loose knot in a soft handkerchief.
2. Hand the knotted handkerchief to the baby with a smile.
3. Encourage the baby to explore and try to undo the knot.
4. Praise the baby for their concentration and efforts.
5. Celebrate together when the knot is successfully unraveled.

Value of activity:

Develops fine motor skills, problem-solving, and focus, fostering confidence and cognitive growth.



Fun Action Song

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Face the baby and do actions while singing any action song you like!
2. Encourage the baby to join in and do the actions too.
3. Perform actions like opening and closing hands, clapping, and patting hands in the lap.
4. Enjoy a lively and interactive playtime with the action song, and repeat whenever you can!

Value of activity:

Promotes coordination, improves imitation skills, and enhances sensory engagement



Naming Family Members

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Point to family members in front of baby, saying names like "Mom," "Dad," "Sister," in your local language.
2. Use names when speaking to your baby, such as "Give the ball to Sarah."
3. Encourage baby to mimic by saying simple family names.
4. Repeat the names with smiles to make learning engaging!

Value of activity:

Introducing family names fosters early language development, social awareness, and strengthens the bond between the baby and family.



Pouring water at Bath-time

Materials: A small mug or container and water.

Steps:

1. During bath time give the baby a small mug or container.
2. Show the baby how to scoop water into the mug and how to pour it.
3. Encouraging the baby to scoop and pour water.
4. Share laughter and joy as you both enjoy the playtime.

Value of activity:

This bath time adventure adds an element of fun to routine activities, fostering a positive association with bath time and promoting sensory and motor development.



11 MONTHS

Story Time

Materials: None (Diaper changing time)

Steps:

1. While sitting with your child, such as during changing the child's diaper, stretch their arms over their head.
2. Tell a funny story about the tallest little child in the world.
3. Use a playful and engaging tone, emphasizing how tall the child is.
4. Enjoy and repeat the storytelling experience whenever you have time!

Value of activity:

Enhances language exposure and understanding



Stack and Tumble

Materials: 3 objects of similar sizes

Steps:

1. Show your baby how to stack the objects, saying "on top of" as you place each one.
2. Help your baby stack the objects, guiding their little hands.
3. Cheer and give your baby a big hug when they place the last object on top.
4. Encourage your baby to knock the stack down and enjoy the fun!

Value of activity:

This activity boosts your baby's motor skills, hand-eye coordination and understanding of balance. Celebrating their success with hugs makes learning fun and builds confidence.



This is My Face

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Sit with the baby and help them learn parts of the face by pointing to the features and naming them, such as pointing at the eye and saying 'eye'.
2. Point to the baby's eye and say 'eye'. Encourage touch when naming.
3. Try with other parts like nose and mouth in a similar way.
4. Praise the baby for touching and participating, repeat the same for all parts of the face!

Value of activity:

Introduces body parts, promotes sensory exploration, and encourages participation through touch and recognition.



Hide and Discover

Materials: Baby's toy or safe objects (such as plastic container or plastic cup)

Steps:

1. Let the baby play with a toy and a plastic container or cup.
2. While the baby is watching, hide the toy under the container.
3. Ask, 'Where is it?' and encourage the baby to lift the container to find the toy. Praise them when they find it!

Value of activity:

"Promotes object permanence, improves spatial awareness and enhances fine motor skills"



Self-Feeding Adventure

Materials: Child-friendly food items

Steps:

1. Prepare child-friendly, easy-to-hold food items.
2. Place the food within the baby's reach.
3. Encourage the baby to pick up and explore the food with their hands.
4. Celebrate each attempt to self-feed with smiles and positive words.
5. Provide gentle guidance if needed, letting them enjoy the sensory experience.

Value of activity:

Encourages independence and a positive relationship with food, fostering a sense of accomplishment as the baby explores self-feeding.



12 MONTHS

I Can Read

Materials: Colorful picture cards or a picture book

Steps:

1. Choose colorful picture cards or a vibrant picture book.
2. Sit with the baby and show them each picture one by one.
3. Use simple words to describe each picture.
4. Encourage the baby to focus on the images and listen to your words.
5. Share smiles and excitement during this visual exploration.

Value of activity:

Enhances the baby's cognitive skills by introducing them to different images and associating words with visual stimuli, promoting language acquisition in a joyful way.



Household Exploration

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Take a short walk around the house with the baby.
2. Point out different things and people, talking about them.
3. Share observations like, "Look at the tree. Do you see the pretty bird?"
4. Identify and talk about things that capture the baby's interest, encourage them to engage!

Value of activity:

Enhances language development, introduces new vocabulary, and creates a stimulating and interactive exploration within the home.



Baby's Baby

Materials: Doll or soft toy

Steps:

1. Hug and rock the doll to demonstrate.
2. Give the doll to the baby and help him hug and rock it.
3. Praise the baby, e.g., "Well done, you are loving the baby."

Value of activities:

Enhances cognitive development and promotes nurturing behavior and sensory engagement.



Copying Actions

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Use action words and demonstrate corresponding actions, such as nodding your head to say yes or no.
2. Shake your head when saying 'no' and see if the child imitates. Praise baby when they do so!
3. When lifting the baby, say 'up,' and when putting the baby down, say 'down.'

Value of activity:

Enhances language development and association of words to actions.



13 MONTHS

Let's Eat With a Spoon

Materials: Child-friendly spoon, soft food (e.g., mashed potatoes, yogurt)

Steps:

1. Offer a child-friendly spoon and a small portion of soft food.
2. Demonstrate how to hold and use the spoon.
3. Encourage the baby to grasp the spoon and bring it to their mouth.
4. Celebrate each spoonful attempt with smiles and positive reinforcement.
5. Provide gentle guidance as needed for a delightful eating experience.

Value of activity:

Develops fine motor skills, hand-eye coordination, and promotes a positive association with mealtime.



Family Spaces Discovery

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Sit with the baby in different corners of the house.
2. Point to the corner and engage in conversation about how each space is used by the family.
3. Encourage the baby to crawl or walk with your support to each corner.
4. Share excitement and positive words as you explore and talk together.

Value of activity:

Boosts spatial awareness, encourages movement, enhances language development, and promotes family connection.



Hide and Seek

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Find various hiding spots around the house.
2. Playfully hide and say, "Peek-a-boo, where am I?"
3. Encourage the baby to crawl or walk towards the hidden spots.
4. Celebrate with joy when the baby finds you, using positive words.

Value of activity:

Enhances gross motor skills, spatial awareness, stimulates curiosity, and bonding.



Following instructions

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Use simple commands like "clap hands" or "wave bye-bye."
2. Demonstrate each action and encourage the baby to imitate.
3. Repeat the commands, providing gentle guidance as needed.
4. Celebrate every attempt with smiles and positive words.

Value of activity:

Develops language comprehension, imitation skills, and reinforces communication.



14 MONTHS

Little Drummer

Materials: Plastic or metal container, object to hit the container (shaker or wooden spoon)

Steps:

1. Get a plastic or metal container and an object for hitting.
2. Allow the baby to play with objects and explore.
3. Help the baby hit the container while saying "bang."
4. Sing a song together while the baby enjoys drumming.
5. Praise the baby, e.g., "You are a great drummer!"

Value of activity:

Promotes sensory exploration, enhances hand-eye coordination, and introduces rhythmic play, creating a delightful and musical playtime.



Kitchen King / Queen

Materials: Ingredients for cooking, such as banana or lentils

Steps:

1. Involve your child in the kitchen while you are cooking.
2. Discuss what you are cooking, explaining the smells, sounds, textures, and tastes.
3. Later, offer the child a piece of banana or some lentils to explore.
4. Encourage them to touch, smell, and, if appropriate, taste the ingredients.
5. Talk to your child about the different sensations and properties.
6. Embrace their natural curiosity and excitement for exploring new things.

Value of activity: Enhances sensory experiences and promotes understanding of different textures, smells, and tastes.



Musical Start and Stop

Materials: Music player or instrument (optional)

Steps:

1. Play music and dance with the baby
2. Stop the music abruptly and freeze in place.
3. Encourage the baby to stop moving when the music stops.
4. Praise and celebrate with smiles and positive words when they pause.
5. Resume dancing when the music restarts, creating a rhythmic playtime.

Value of activity: Provides a fun way for the baby to engage with sound, movement, and responsive play, promoting both physical and cognitive development.



15 MONTHS

Playing with Dough

Materials: Soft playdough in various colors

Steps:

1. Offer the baby different-colored playdough.
2. Show how to make simple shapes like circles, squares, and triangles.
3. Encourage the baby to touch and explore the dough, creating shapes.
4. Celebrate their efforts with smiles and positive words.
5. Explore making different shapes together for a creative experience.

Value of activity: Enhances fine motor skills, encourages sensory exploration, and introduces basic shapes.



Let's Make Animal Sounds

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Introduce simple animal sounds like "tweet, tweet" for birds or "moo" for cows.
2. Imitate the sounds with enthusiasm and encourage the baby to join in.
3. Make corresponding gestures or movements for each animal.
4. Celebrate the baby's attempts to imitate with smiles and positive words.
5. Explore various animal sounds together, creating a playful mimicking session.

Value of activity: Stimulates the baby's auditory senses, promotes early language skills, and adds a fun element to playtime by incorporating gestures.



I feed you, You feed me!

Materials: Baby-friendly food items, small spoon

Steps:

1. Sit facing the baby with baby-friendly food nearby.
2. Take turns feeding each other with a small spoon.
3. Use positive words and smiles during the feeding exchange.
4. Encourage the baby to hold the spoon and feed you.
5. Celebrate the shared feeding experience with laughter and joy.

Value of activity: Promotes bonding through shared experiences, encourages the development of fine motor skills, and introduces the concept of give-and-take in a playful and enjoyable manner.



Who is that in the Mirror?

Materials: Any mirror in the home

Steps:

1. Find a mirror in the home and bring the baby in front of it.
2. Hold the baby and ask, "Where is baby?" while looking in the mirror.
3. Encourage the baby to touch their own image, saying, "Ahh! There's baby! What a smart baby."
4. Have fun exploring expressions and movements together in front of the mirror.

Value of activity: Allows the baby to discover their own reflection, fostering a sense of self and creating joyful moments of connection with the caregiver.



16 MONTHS

Climbing the Cushion Mountain

Materials: Mattresses or cushions

Steps:

1. Create a soft and safe pile of mattresses or cushions.
2. Encourage the child to climb up with your support if needed.
3. Celebrate each step upward with praise and positive words.
4. Once at the top, encourage a gentle descent, supporting as necessary.
5. Share smiles and excitement during this climb-and-descend adventure.

Value of activity: Enhances gross motor skills, spatial awareness, and builds confidence.



Following Instructions

Materials: Familiar objects like a ball or a comb

Steps:

1. Engage the child by using their name and selecting familiar objects.
2. Give simple directions such as "Zeenat, pick up the ball" or "Zeenat, bring me the comb."
3. Encourage the child to follow the instructions, providing guidance if needed.
4. Use positive reinforcement like smiles and praise for their efforts.
5. Repeat with different objects and directions to make it an enjoyable learning experience.

Value of activity: Builds a connection between the child's name and familiar objects, builds ability to follow simple directions, lays ground for language and cognitive development.



Lets clean up!

Materials: Materials: Basket or bucket

Steps:

1. Introduce the large basket or bucket for collecting toys.
2. Encourage the child to pick up and place toys in the container.
3. Use positive words and praise as they tidy up.
4. Make it a game by counting or naming each toy together.
5. Celebrate the accomplishment with smiles and encouragement.

Value of activity: This simple cleanup activity teaches the child the importance of tidying up after play, instilling good habits and supporting the development of motor skills.



Are they the same?

Materials: 2 sets of different items (such as 2 spoons and 2 cups)

Steps:

1. Show the baby 2 spoons and 2 cups, saying their names.
2. Point out that the 2 spoons are the 'same' and the 2 cups are the 'same.'
3. Give the child all four objects and ask them to put the 'same' objects together.
4. Offer help if needed and praise the child when they correctly sort the objects!

Value of activity: Enhances cognitive skills and fosters problem-solving through hands-on sorting.



Pull it Along

Materials: Any object or toy and a short piece of string

Steps:

1. Tie an object or toy to the end of a short piece of string.
2. Hold the string and pull the toy while walking, saying, 'This is my car. I can pull it. Let's go for a drive. Vroom, Vroom!'
3. Give the string to the child and encourage them to pull the toy while walking.
4. Praise the child when they walk and pull the toy!

Value of activity: Enhances gross motor skills, fosters imaginative play, and promotes physical movement.



17 MONTHS

Pretend Play with Everyday Objects

Materials: Everyday objects from around the house

Steps:

1. Gather safe and suitable everyday objects from the house.
2. Demonstrate how to use each object through pretend play.
3. Encourage the child to imitate and engage in their own pretend play.
4. Use positive words to describe their imaginative play.
5. Join in the play, making it a collaborative and enjoyable experience.

Value of activity: Enhances creativity through exploring child's imagination, cognitive development and language development.



Bedtime Story

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Think of a short, soothing story for bedtime.
2. Snuggle with the baby in a comfortable and quiet space.
3. Use gentle and expressive storytelling tones.
4. Point to pictures if using a picture book.
5. Conclude with a calming phrase or routine to signal bedtime.

Value of activity: Fosters language development, emotional connection, and establishes a bedtime routine.



Shadow Play Delight

Materials: Light source (lamp or flashlight), flat surface

Steps:

1. Set up a light source in a dimly lit room.
2. Create shadows with your hands or use simple objects.
3. Encourage the child to watch and explore the shadows.
4. Name and discuss shadow figures.
5. Engage in a gentle shadow chase or name the shadow figures.

Value of activity: Enhances visual tracking, stimulates imagination, and promotes interaction as the child explores the magical world of shadows.



Discovering Body Parts

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Sit with the baby in a comfortable and playful position.
2. Ask the baby, "Where is your hand? Where is your nose?"
3. Encourage the baby to point to the mentioned body parts.
4. Use positive reinforcement with smiles and praise.
5. Repeat the activity, introducing new body parts gradually.

Value of activity: Encourages language development as the baby associates words with specific body parts in a fun and engaging way.



18 MONTHS

Fun with Scribbles

Materials: Crayon/pencil, and paper

Steps:

1. Sit with baby and use a crayon to scribble on paper while they watch.
2. Allow the baby to hold the crayon in any way and in any hand.
3. Praise the baby for any type of marks they make!
4. Have fun and make different shapes for the baby to follow.

Value of activity: Encourages fine motor skills and introduces creative expression.



Joyful Songtime

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Choose a simple and upbeat song.
2. Sit or stand with the baby in a playful position.
3. Sing the chosen song with enthusiasm and joy.
4. Incorporate hand movements or clapping for added fun.
5. Engage the baby by encouraging them to join in or mimic gestures.

Value of activity: Encourages language development through song, and strengthens the connection between parent and child as they share in the joy of music together.



Touch and Bring

Materials: 3 common and safe objects (e.g., shoe, cup, ball)

Steps:

1. Think of 3 objects in the house that the child can easily get, like a shoe, cup, or ball.
2. Sit with the child and play a game asking the child to bring each object to you.
3. Praise the child when they get the correct object.
4. Encourage the child to say the name of each object, praise when they do so!

Value of activity: Enhances gross motor skills, promotes object recognition, and encourages language development



Open and Close

Materials: Empty box or jar with a lid

Steps:

1. Provide a sturdy box or jar with a secure lid.
2. Demonstrate opening and closing the box or jar.
3. Encourage the child to imitate the action.
4. Use positive words to praise their efforts.
5. Place small, safe items inside for added discovery.

Value of activity:

Enhances fine motor skills, introduces cause and effect, and promotes sensory exploration.



18 MONTHS

Cleaning Together

Materials: Child-safe cleaning supplies, small cloth or sponge

Steps:

1. Invite the child to join you during your household chores.
2. Provide them with child-safe cleaning supplies and a small cloth or sponge.
3. Playfully demonstrate cleaning actions, using positive words.
4. Encourage the child to mimic the actions in a fun and pretend manner.
5. Make it a routine, turning household chores into playful and interactive moments.

Value of activity: Integrates the child into the household routine, encourages responsibility, and fosters imaginative play.



Matching Big and Small Circle

Materials: Paper or cardboard cut out in the shape of a big circle and a small circle

Steps:

1. Use cups or bowls to draw the outline of a big circle and a little circle on 2 pieces of paper or cardboard.
2. Cut out the circles from any one piece of paper.
3. Describe each circle using the words 'big circle' and 'small circle'.
4. Carefully show the child how to place the cut out circles on top of the circles on paper.
5. Ask child to place one circle at a time.
6. Praise the child when she places them correctly!

Value of activity: Promotes cognitive development through solving simple puzzles and improves vocabulary by learning new words such as big, small and circle.



Sorting Same Objects

Materials: 4 pieces of 2 different items (such as 4 cups and 4 spoons OR 4 leaves and 4 sticks)

Steps:

1. Sit with the baby and allow them to play with the objects.
2. Show the child how cups are the 'same' and spoons are 'same' (or leaves and sticks).
3. Mix up the objects and ask the child to put all the 'same' objects together.
4. Praise the child when they do so and repeat with different objects!

Value of activity: Enhances cognitive skills, introduces the concept of sorting, and fosters problem-solving



20 MONTHS

Greetings and Actions

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Encourage the child to do the actions you name.
2. Walk a little away and ask the child to wave 'bye-bye.'
3. Give the child an object and see if they say 'thank you.'
4. Ask the child to 'clap hands', praise the child every time they follow the actions correctly!

Value of activity:

Promotes imitation and action comprehension, encourages language development, and creates a lively and interactive playtime focused on action words.



Sweeping Together

Materials: Broom, dustpan, dustbin

Steps:

1. Invite your child to join you in sweeping, saying, "It's time to sweep together!"
2. Ask the child to hold the dustpan while you sweep.
3. Encourage them to throw the dirt into the dustbin.
4. Take turns holding the dustpan for each other.
5. Positively discipline the child if needed, emphasizing the importance of helping.

Value of activity: Involves the child in everyday chores and instills a positive attitude towards cleanliness and cooperation, promoting valuable life skills.



Opening and Closing Doors

Materials: Child-safe door or cupboard

Steps:

1. Choose a child-safe door or cupboard.
2. Demonstrate opening and closing the door.
3. Encourage the child to imitate the action.
4. Use positive words to praise their efforts.
5. Turn it into a playful game of "open" and "close."

Value of activity:

Enhances fine motor skills, introduces cause and effect, and promotes spatial awareness.



Let's Pretend - Animals and Birds

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Talk about animals your child likes. Use hands for bird and cat.
2. Make animal sounds together – roar, tweet, meow!
3. Sit on the floor with your child, pretend to be animals.
4. Have a giggle-filled time playing together!

Value of activity: Sparks imagination, builds words, and brings joy through simple and friendly animal play.



21 MONTHS

Over and Under

Materials: Various objects, a container

Steps:

1. Allow the child to explore different objects.
2. Show the child how to put objects on top and under the container, using words like 'on top' and 'under'.
3. Encourage the child to replicate the actions independently when you say the words 'on top' and 'under'.
4. Praise the child enthusiastically when she successfully places objects in the correct positions.

Value of activity: Introduces the concepts of 'on top' and 'under' and allows the child to actively engage in sorting and spatial understanding, fostering both cognitive and motor skills.



Cup Tower

Materials: Plastic or metal cups

Steps:

1. Collect a few plastic or metal cups.
2. Demonstrate how to stack them into a tower.
3. Celebrate by knocking down the towers together.
4. Encourage the child to throw the ball back to you.
5. Discuss the activity with the child, asking questions and using descriptive words.

Value of activity: Provides a fun and engaging experience for the child and encourages exploration and conversation, fostering an understanding of the physical world around them.



Copy the Rhythm

Materials: Plastic container, spoons, keys

Steps:

1. Create a homemade instrument by placing spoons and keys inside a plastic container.
2. While cooking, shake the container to create sounds and establish a rhythm.
3. Clap a certain rhythm and observe if the child tries to copy the beat with the homemade instrument.
4. Allow the child to take turns leading and you follow their rhythm.
5. Discuss different sounds and patterns, encouraging the child's attention and creativity.

Value of activity: Engages the child's sense of hearing, encourages exploration of sounds, fostering cognitive development and an understanding of unique patterns.



Shoe Sorting and Matching

Materials: 4 different adult size shoes (big) and 4 different child size shoes (little)

Steps:

1. Mix adult and child-size shoes in a pile.
2. Show the child how to sort the shoes into 'big' and 'little.'
3. Mix the shoes again and ask the child to independently sort them.
4. Praise the child when they correctly distinguish between 'big' and 'little' shoes.

Value of activity: Engages the child in a playful sorting game and encourages observation and discrimination of sizes, fostering cognitive development.



22 MONTHS

Hide and Seek with Doll

Materials: Doll or stuffed bear

Steps:

1. Hide the doll while asking, "Where is the doll?"
2. Let your child find it, creating excitement.
3. Praise and play the game again for added fun.
4. Boosts concentration, engages intellect, and fosters imagination.

Value of activity: Enhances concentration and imagination, promoting cognitive development in a playful setting.



Play with a ball

Materials: Soft ball or rolled-up socks

Steps:

1. Use a soft ball or roll a pair of socks into a ball.
2. Give the ball to the child for play.
3. Throw the ball to the child, using the word 'throw.'
4. Encourage the child to throw the ball back to you.
5. Enjoy the back-and-forth play, having fun with the ball.

Value of activity: Enhances gross motor skills, hand-eye coordination, and introduces the concept of reciprocal play.



Colorful Hands

Materials: Kumkum, haldi, and other safe household colors, large paper or cardboard

Steps:

1. Lay out a large piece of paper or cardboard for a canvas.
2. Provide child-safe household colors like kumkum and haldi.
3. Encourage the child to dip their hands and playfully paint on the canvas.
4. Use positive words to describe the colors and celebrate creativity.
5. Allow the child to freely explore and create with the colors.

Value of activity: Enhances sensory exploration, creativity, and introduces colors.



Story Time with a Picture Book

Materials: Picture book

Steps:

1. Choose a picture book suitable for your child's age.
2. Sit together and read the book aloud.
3. Point at pictures and name them, encouraging the child to repeat.
4. Discuss the story, asking questions or sharing thoughts.
5. Make up stories related to the pictures or characters in the book.
6. Enjoy the interactive and engaging experience of reading together.

Value of activity: Enhances language development through reading and naming, promotes cognitive skills through storytelling, fosters a love for books and reading.



23 MONTHS

Playing with Water

Materials: Bucket of water, child-friendly glasses or cups

Steps:

1. Fill a bucket with water in a safe play area.
2. Provide child-friendly glasses or cups for scooping and pouring.
3. Encourage the child to explore freely, pouring and splashing.
4. Use positive words to describe the water play and their actions.
5. Join in the fun, making it a shared water adventure.

Value of activity: This water play activity fosters sensory development, fine motor skills, and joyous exploration, encouraging a positive relationship with water.



Describing Foods

Materials: Any foods (banana, boiled eggs, etc.)

Steps:

1. Show any food items to baby, let them touch and feel it.
2. Describe and ask questions such as "Is the banana squishy, sweet, and slippery?" or "Is the egg warm and hard?"
3. Observe your child's response and encourage them to react and speak.
4. Use more foods to build their vocabulary and understanding.

Value of activity: Introduces descriptive words, enhances vocabulary, and encourages observational and communication skills during mealtime.



Name: Sound Patterns

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Create sound patterns, for example, "Kaaw ... kaaw."
2. Play with your child by making these sound patterns and ask them to repeat.
3. Prompt the child to create a new sound pattern, and you imitate them.
4. Increase the challenge by going faster or adding more sounds.
5. Take turns coming up with creative sound patterns.
6. Enjoy the playful exchange of sound symphonies together.

Value of activity: Enhances auditory discrimination skills. Promotes creativity in sound production. Encourages turn-taking and interactive play.



Is it red or not?



Materials: None

Steps:

1. Introduce the color red by showing examples or pointing to red objects.
2. Playfully describe the color red with positive words.
3. Ask, "Is the object red or not?" for different items.
4. Encourage the child to respond, providing support if needed.
5. Offer positive reinforcement for correct answers and guide gently if they find it challenging.

Value of activity: Introduces color recognition, promotes cognitive development, and encourages active participation.

Sing a Nursery Rhyme



Materials: None

Steps:

1. Choose a simple and engaging nursery rhyme.
2. Sit or stand with the baby in a comfortable position.
3. Sing the chosen nursery rhyme with expressive and rhythmic tones.
4. Incorporate gentle gestures or movements for added fun.
5. Encourage the baby to join in, either by singing along or mimicking gestures.

Value of activity: Enhances language development, promotes rhythm appreciation, and strengthens bonding through a shared and joyful singing.

Open Hands Challenge



Materials: None

Steps:

1. Make a fist with your hands, not holding it too tight.
2. Encourage the child to try to open your fist.
3. Use the phrase "Open Handa" or any fun cue.
4. Allow the child to explore different ways to open the fist.
5. Repeat the activity with enthusiasm and encouragement.

Value of activity: Enhances fine motor skills and finger strength along with encouraging problem-solving as the child figures out how to open the fist.

24 MONTHS

Let's take a Walk Outside



Materials: None

Steps:

1. Take your child for a walk outside.
2. Point out and talk about various things in the surroundings.
3. Encourage the child to repeat words associated with what they see.
4. Discuss nature, objects, colors, and anything interesting.
5. Make it an interactive conversation, asking questions and sharing observations.

Value of activity: Promotes observation skills and curiosity about the surroundings, fosters language development through interactive communication and repetition.

Is it blue or not?

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Begin by revisiting the color red, reminding the child of its features. Celebrate what they have learnt "You're right, this is red!"
2. Introduce the color blue, showing examples or pointing to blue objects.
3. Playfully describe the color blue with positive words.
4. Ask, "Is the object blue or not?" for various items.
5. Encourage the child to respond, reinforcing their understanding of red and acknowledging correct answers.
6. Offer positive reinforcement for correct answers and guide gently if they find it challenging.

Value of activity: This sequential color activity builds on previous learning and promotes engagement by recalling the earlier color, fostering a holistic understanding of color concepts.



25 MONTHS

Pretend Play: Talking on the phone

Materials: Pretend phone or toy phone

Steps:

1. Sit with your child and introduce a pretend phone or toy phone, saying, "Let's have a special phone to talk to each other!"
2. Demonstrate how to hold the phone and initiate the conversation, "Ring, ring! Hello baby! What are you doing?"
3. Engage in pretend conversations using simple phrases, encouraging your child to respond, "Can you say, 'I am playing?'"
4. Use positive words to acknowledge their pretend communication, saying, "I love hearing about your day! You're doing great talking on the phone!"

Value of activity: Fosters a sense of connection and communication between parent and child, providing a fun and creative space for them to share and express themselves.



Up and Down Exploration

Materials: Sturdy chair, bed, or sofa

Steps:

1. Place a sturdy chair, bed, or sofa in a safe area.
2. Encourage your child to climb up onto the furniture with your assistance if needed.
3. Celebrate their achievement with positive words and smiles.
4. Guide them in a controlled descent, emphasizing safety.
5. Repeat the activity, fostering confidence and coordination.

Value of activity: Provides a physical challenge in a safe environment, promoting coordination and a sense of achievement while fostering a positive attitude towards physical activity.



Activity: Matching shapes

Materials: Paper or Cardboard, Crayons or other colours

Steps:

1. Draw a triangle, circle and square on two pieces of paper or cardboard.
2. Cut out the shapes from any one piece of paper.
3. Ask the child to match the shapes by placing them on top.
4. As they are matching say the names of the shapes to the child.
5. Focus on nurturing the child's ability to match similar looking shapes by showing them how it is to be done.
6. Encourage the child to try on their own and praise them for their creativity and efforts.

Value of activity: Promotes cognitive development through solving simple puzzles and improves vocabulary by learning new words and phrases such as names of shapes, 'on top of' etc.



Is it yellow or not?

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Begin by revisiting the colors red and blue, reminding the child of their features.
2. Introduce the color yellow, showing examples or pointing to yellow objects.
3. Playfully describe the color yellow with positive words.
4. Ask, "Is the object yellow or not?" for various items.
5. Encourage the child to respond, reinforcing their understanding of red and blue, and acknowledging correct answers.
6. Review the previously learned colors, saying, "You're right, this is red! And this is blue!"

Value of activity: This sequential color activity builds on the foundation of previous learning, promotes engagement through recall, and creates a well-rounded understanding of color concepts.



26 MONTHS

Telling a story about your childhood

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Sit with your child in a comfortable and cozy space.
2. Share a simple and engaging story from your childhood.
3. Use expressive tones and gestures to make the story come alive.
4. Encourage the child to ask questions or share their thoughts.
5. Conclude the storytime by asking if they'd like to hear another story.

Value of activity: Fosters parent-child bonding, stimulates imagination, and promotes language development.



Sensory Play

Materials: Sand or mud, cups, buckets, containers

Steps:

1. Set up a play area with sand or mud.
2. Provide cups and buckets for transferring.
3. Encourage the child to scoop and transfer the material from one container to another.
4. Discuss the texture, feel, and sensations of the sand or mud.
5. Explore different pouring and scooping techniques.
6. Have a messy and enjoyable sensory playtime.

Value of activity: Enhances sensory exploration through touch and feel and promotes fine motor skills through scooping and pouring. Encourages creativity and imagination during play.



Let's Dance Together

Materials: Music, radio

Steps:

1. Play music from the radio.
2. Hold the child's hands and dance together.
3. Encourage the child to move their head, legs, and arms to the rhythm of the music.
4. Create a dance routine or follow the music's beat.
5. Invite other members of the house to join in and have a joyful dance party together.

Value of activity: Promotes physical activity and coordination. Enhances rhythm and musical awareness.



Green Discovery and Color Recap



Materials: None

Steps:

1. Begin by revisiting the colors red, blue, and yellow, reminding the child of their features.
2. Introduce the color green, showing examples or pointing to green objects.
3. Playfully describe the color green with positive words.
4. Ask, "Is the object green or not?" for various items.
5. Encourage the child to respond, reinforcing their understanding of previously learned colors and acknowledging correct answers.
6. Review the earlier colors, saying, "You're right, this is red! And this is blue! This one is yellow!"

Value of activity: This activity continues to build on the child's knowledge, promotes engagement by recalling the colors learned earlier, and contributes to a holistic understanding of color concepts.

Act like Papa

Materials: Dad's shoes, clothing, a container, pretend spoon

Steps:

1. Talk with the child about the various things moms do.
2. Allow the child to dress up like mom by putting on her shoes and clothing.
3. Role-play activities, like "Papa is cooking."
4. Use a container to pretend to cook.
5. Stir an imaginary spoon in a pot.
6. Pretend to taste the delicious imaginary dish.
7. Have fun together, engaging in imaginative play!

Value of activity: Encourages imaginative play and creativity. Strengthens the bond between caregiver and child. Promotes understanding of different roles and activities in daily life.

Fast and Slow

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Prompt your child to have a Fast and Slow Race with you.
2. Find a starting line and count together, then say "Go!"
3. As you run, call out "slow!" and observe if your child adjusts their speed.
4. Call out "fast" and "slow" intermittently, discussing the pace variations.
5. Count how many times you ran fast and how many times you ran slow.
6. Discuss the game and reinforce the importance of listening to directions.

Value of activity: Teaches listening and following directions. Also helps in practicing emotional and action control.



Objects and their Uses

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Think of 3 or 4 objects that the child knows.
2. Point at each object and ask the child to name them.
3. Explain the use of each object, for example, "Cup. We drink water from the cup."
4. Encourage the child to repeat the names and uses.
5. Discuss each object, fostering understanding and vocabulary development.

Value of activity: Enhances vocabulary through object naming and promotes understanding of object functions and uses.



27 MONTHS

Smile and wink

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Smile at the baby and wink, repeating it several times.
2. Encourage the baby to observe and try to imitate you.
3. Count how many smiles and winks you share together.
4. Celebrate each attempt with praise and positive reinforcement.

Value of activity: Teaches the baby non-verbal communication through facial expressions. Enhances observational skills and the ability to imitate. Fosters a sense of connection and shared joy through smiling and winking.



28 MONTHS

Act like mumma

Materials: Mothers things like shoes, clothes, etc

Steps:

1. Assume the role of mom in a playful manner.
2. Imitate mom's actions, gestures, and way of speaking.
3. Engage the baby in activities that mimic what mama does (sings to baby, does work around the house, talks on the phone, reads a book, etc)
4. Encourage the baby to observe and participate in the pretend play.
5. Enjoy the interactive and imaginative experience together.

Value of activity: Fosters imaginative play and creativity. Strengthens the bond between caregiver and baby. Provides an opportunity for the baby to observe and understand different roles.



Filling up water

Materials: Empty bottle, mug, bucket, water

Steps:

1. Place the empty bottle on a flat surface.
2. Fill the mug with water and pour it into the bottle.
3. Discuss the process with the baby, saying, "Fill the bottle with water."
4. Let the baby pour water from the mug into the bottle with your assistance.
5. Explore variations like using a bucket for a different pouring experience.

Value of activity: Enhances fine motor skills through pouring. Promotes sensory exploration with water. Encourages language development through discussion of the activity.



What did we do today?

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Begin by discussing waking up and dressing in the morning.
2. Relate activities to the time of day, progressing through the day's events.
3. Talk about eating, playing, and other activities.
4. Act out the actions with the baby for a more engaging experience.
5. Conclude by discussing going to bed at nighttime.
6. Encourage the baby to share their experiences and thoughts about each activity.

Value of activity: Enhances language development through daily routine discussions. Promotes time awareness and sequencing of events. Fosters interactive learning through role-playing and conversation.



Clues to Find Me

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Invite the baby to play hide-and-seek.
2. Ask the baby to hide while you count.
3. Search for the baby while providing clues, such as "I can hear laughing near the door."
4. Use descriptive language to guide your search.
5. Celebrate with excitement when you find the baby.
6. Switch roles and let the baby hide while you find them.
7. Encourage the baby to provide clues.

Value of activity: Develops problem-solving skills, promotes self-control and patience during the hiding process and enhances language development through descriptive clues.



28 MONTHS

Singing and Laughing Together

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Choose a favorite nursery rhyme.
2. Sing the nursery rhyme to the baby with enthusiasm.
3. Encourage the baby to clap, move, or join in with simple actions.
4. Repeat the nursery rhyme, inviting the baby to sing along if they can.
5. Make it a joyful and interactive experience.

Value of activity: Enhances language development, promotes bonding and encourages cognitive development through exposure to melodies and rhymes.



Mud Masterpiece

Materials: Outdoor mud patch or soft soil

Steps:

1. Find a suitable patch of mud or soil outside the house.
2. Sit with the baby and show them how to draw in the mud using fingers.
3. Encourage the baby to explore and create their own mud drawings.
4. Talk about the shapes, lines, or patterns as you draw together.
5. Allow the baby to experiment with different finger movements.
6. Celebrate their muddy masterpiece with enthusiasm.

Value of activity: Enhances sensory exploration through touch and texture, promotes creativity and fine motor skills through finger drawing.



Which Animal Am I?

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Choose an animal, like a cat, and talk about its features, e.g., "A cat has whiskers and a long tail."
2. Use your hands to show the baby the whiskers.
3. Make the sounds associated with the animal, e.g., "Meow" for a cat.
4. Get on the floor with the baby and pretend to be the chosen animal, mimicking its movements.
5. Encourage the baby to imitate the sounds and actions.

Value of activity: Enhances language development through animal descriptions, promotes sensory exploration through mimicry and sounds and fosters creativity and imaginative play.



Solving a Puzzle

Materials: Paper or cardboard, drawing utensils, scissors

Steps:

1. Draw a stickman on a piece of paper or cardboard.
2. Cut the paper into three pieces – top (head), middle (body), and bottom (legs).
3. Explain that the head goes on top, the body in the middle, and the legs on the bottom.
4. Pull the pieces apart and ask the baby to put them back together to recreate the man.
5. Praise the baby when they fit the pieces together correctly.

Value of activity: Enhances problem-solving skills, while developing fine motor skills and developing awareness of body parts.



30 MONTHS

A Magical Tent

Materials: Two sturdy chairs, a blanket, bed sheet or towel

Steps:

1. Cover two sturdy chairs with a blanket or towel to create a tent.
2. Invite the baby inside this special home and make it a comfortable space for games.
3. Encourage the baby to bring toys inside for imaginative play.
4. Together, give this special place a fun and creative name.
5. Explore games, stories, and activities inside the tent together.

Value of activity: Fosters imaginative play and creativity and creates a cozy and magical space for exploration.



Folding Clothes Together

Materials: Clean clothes

Steps:

1. Gather clean clothes for folding.
2. Sit with the baby and show them how to fold clothes.
3. Encourage the baby to imitate by folding a piece of clothing.
4. Praise and celebrate their efforts in helping with the laundry.
5. Make it a fun and interactive activity, talking about colors and clothing types.

Value of activity: Enhances fine motor skills through folding and promotes collaboration and bonding during a daily task.



What Happens at Work

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Share with the baby what Mama or Papa does at work.
2. Use simple language to explain tasks, for example, farming.
3. Talk about activities like sowing seeds, watering the soil, and removing weeds.
4. Encourage the baby to ask questions or mimic some actions.
5. Make it engaging by incorporating gestures and enthusiasm.

Value of activity: Enhances language development through storytelling and promotes curiosity and imaginative play as the baby learns about the world around them.



Whose is this?

Materials: Various familiar objects (a shirt, a watch, a phone)

Steps:

1. Show the baby different objects one by one
2. Ask, "Whose is this?" for each object.
3. Encourage the baby to identify or point to the owner (e.g., "Mommy's phone," "Daddy's shoe")
4. Ask the baby what the person does with - papa wears the shoe before leaving the house
5. Praise and affirm their responses.

Value of activity: Promotes cognitive development by enabling the child to make associations between the object, persons and their actions. It also enables language development through identification and naming.



31 MONTHS

Touch and Name Challenge

Materials: Objects in the house (e.g., door, bed, chair, table)

Steps:

1. Name 3 or 4 easily accessible objects in the house.
2. Ask the baby to touch and repeat the name of each object.
3. Praise the baby when they correctly touch and name the object.
4. Switch roles and let the baby choose objects for you to touch and name.
5. Have a joyful time playing and learning together!

Value of activity: Enhances vocabulary and object recognition skills.



Scribbling Fun

Materials: Crayon or pencil, paper

Steps:

1. Encourage the baby to use a crayon and scribble all over the paper.
2. Take another crayon and demonstrate making circular scribbles.
3. Encourage the baby to imitate by creating their own circular marks.
4. Praise the baby for making circular marks on the paper.

Value of activity: Enhances fine motor skills through scribbling and introduces basic shapes and patterns.



Naming Clothes

Materials: Baby's and family member's clothes

Steps:

1. Assist the baby in naming the clothes they are wearing.
2. Ask the baby to show you each piece of clothing when you say its name.
3. If the baby is able, encourage them to name each clothing item themselves.
4. Celebrate correct responses with a high five or praise.
5. Point to your own clothes and see if the baby can identify their names.

Value of activity: Strengthens vocabulary related to clothing items and promotes recognition and understanding of everyday objects.



Matching Colours Game

Materials: Colorful objects or cards in red, blue, and yellow

Steps:

1. Gather objects or cards in red, blue, and yellow.
2. Show each color and say its name.
3. Ask the baby to match objects of the same color.
4. Celebrate when the baby successfully matches red with red, blue with blue, and yellow with yellow.

Value of activity: Develops color recognition and enhances cognitive abilities through matching



32 MONTHS

Act Like Grandpa

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Talk with the child about the various things grandparents do.
2. Allow the child to dress up like grandparents by putting on their shoes and clothing.
3. Role-play activities, like "Grandpa is feeding the cows".
4. Say things that grandpa usually says, or stories that grandpa usually tells.
5. Have fun together, engaging in imaginative play!

Value of activity: Fosters imaginative play and creativity. Strengthens the bond between caregiver and baby. Promotes language development through storytelling and role-playing.



Lets Drive a Cycle Together

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Pretend to be a truck driver by holding an imaginary steering wheel, tooting the horn, and making engine sounds.
2. Let the baby follow behind you as you "drive."
3. Talk about your journey, mentioning destinations like the market or shop.
4. Use terms like 'fast/slow,' 'left/right,' 'long/short,' and pretend to pick up vegetables.
5. Swap roles, letting the baby be the driver while you follow behind.
6. Encourage the baby to describe their journey and have fun!

Value of activity: Encourages imaginative play and creativity. Enhances language skills through storytelling and role-playing. Promotes the understanding of directional concepts and spatial awareness.



Nature Story Time

Materials: None

Steps:

1. While outdoors, prompt the baby to observe rocks, trees, animals, etc.
2. Utilize these natural elements to recount a beloved story or sing a favorite song.
3. For instance, tell the story of "The Thirsty Crow," or other animal friends using the surrounding environment.
4. Encourage the baby to share their thoughts on the objects and animals they recognize.
5. Foster a conversation about the familiar elements, promoting information gathering.

Value of activity: Enhances observational skills and curiosity about the environment and improves listening and speaking skills.



Comparing Sizes

Materials: Three different-sized leaves or sticks

Steps:

1. Find leaves or sticks in three different sizes.
2. Use words like 'big, medium, and little' to describe each size.
3. Ask the baby to repeat the size words after you.
4. Call out the sizes and have the baby point to the corresponding leaf.
5. Praise the baby when they correctly identify the sizes.

Value of activity: Develops vocabulary related to size, enhances observational and language skills.



Stringing Adventure

Materials: A sieve, colorful yarn or string

Steps:

1. Demonstrate how to hold the sieve steady on a flat surface.
2. Show the baby how to thread the yarn through the holes, starting from the top.
3. Guide the baby's hands to weave the yarn through the holes, encouraging their fine motor skills.
4. Celebrate each successful threading with praise and excitement.
5. Explore different patterns and colors together for added fun!

Value of activity: Enhances fine motor skills and hand-eye coordination.



Searching for Colours

Materials: Objects of different colors (e.g., leaf, door, sock, grass)

Steps:

1. Find two objects of the same color, like a green leaf and door.
2. Show the baby the objects and describe the colour and name such as, "Green leaf."
3. Help the baby find more items of the same color, e.g., sock and grass and encourage them when they do!
4. Name one color at a time, making it a joyful color search.

Value of activity: Boosts color recognition, vocabulary, and turns learning into a fun and engaging exploration.



Let's Dance Together

Materials: Music player or radio

Steps:

1. Play lively music from the radio.
2. Hold the baby's hands and dance together.
3. Encourage the baby to move their head, legs, and arms to the rhythm.
4. Create a fun dance routine together.
5. Invite other household members to join in for a joyous dance party!

Value of activity: Promotes physical activity and coordination, enhances rhythmic and motor skills along with family bonding and shared enjoyment.



33 MONTHS

Name: Sorting Bottle Caps

Materials: Plastic bottle caps in three different colours

Steps:

1. Display the bottle caps and name each color.
2. Ask the baby to sort the caps by matching colours.
3. Cheer for their efforts in sorting by color.
4. Enjoy the activity together!

Value of activity: Develops colour recognition and sorting skills and improves fine motor skills through handling and arranging objects.



Name: Look, I Can Drive!

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Pretend to be a car, plane, or motorbike with different movements and sounds.
2. Encourage the baby to join in the imaginative play.
3. Ask, "What sound does a [chosen vehicle] make?"
4. Have fun together exploring different imaginary journeys!

Value of activity: Stimulates creativity and imagination and develops language skills by associating sounds with objects.



34 MONTHS

Name: Nursery Rhyme

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Sing a nursery rhyme to the baby alone with actions.
2. Encourage the baby to imitate the actions and repeat the words.
3. Enjoy the interaction and make it a playful experience.

Value of activity: Enhances language skills through song and actions and promotes imitation and coordination.



Name: Fun Ball Game

Materials: Ball, cloth ball, or sock ball

Steps:

1. Give the baby a ball to play with.
2. Form a circle with others in the family
3. Throw, bounce, or roll the ball to someone in the circle.
4. The receiver performs an action (e.g., jump) for others to copy.
5. The person with the ball passes it to someone else to continue the fun.
6. Enjoy playing together and exploring various actions!

Value of activity: Enhances gross motor skills such as picking up, catching and throwing and teaches the child about social interaction and cooperation within a group.



Guess the Animal

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Get down on the floor and mimic an animal's actions and sounds.
2. Invite the baby to guess the animal you're pretending to be.
3. Praise them when they correctly identify the animal.
4. Repeat the game with different animal actions for more fun!

Value of activity: Enhances cognitive skills through observation and deduction, a boost in vocabulary by associating animals with sounds and movements.



Touch the Colour

Materials: Colored objects or cards

Steps:

1. Present colorful objects or cards to the baby.
2. Say, "Touch the color Red," and encourage the baby to touch the object or card of the named color.
3. Celebrate each correct touch with praise and excitement.

Value of activity: Develops color recognition skills, and the positive reinforcement helps the child to make mistakes and learn new things confidently.



35 MONTHS

Mumma Says

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Start a game of "Mumma says" with the baby.
2. Give commands like "Mumma says sit" or "Mumma says stand."
3. Encourage the baby to follow the instructions.
4. Praise and celebrate their actions when you say "Simran says."
5. Try fun variations to challenge the child's listening and responding skills.

Value of activity: Enhances listening skills and improves the child's ability to follow instructions.



What's in the Bag?

Materials: A bag with safe and familiar toys

Steps:

1. Ask the baby to close their eyes.
2. Take out one object at a time and give it to the baby.
3. Let them touch and feel.
4. Now ask them to guess what it is!
5. Praise and encourage the baby for guessing correctly.
6. Give them clues to figure out the right answer.

Value of activity: Promotes sensory stimulation and enables improved cognitive development through guessing.



Name: Where's the Partner?



Materials: Various objects with clear pairs (e.g., lock and key, shoe and sock)

Steps:

1. Introduce pairs like lock and key, saying each pair's name.
2. Show one object and ask, "Where's the partner?"
3. Help the baby find and connect the matching items.
4. Cheer for the baby's success in matching each pair.

Value of activity: Develops cognitive skills by recognizing associations between objects and their uses.

Name: My Name Is...

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Ask the baby, "What's your first name?"
2. When the baby responds, say, "That's right! Your name is [First Name]."
3. Ask, "And what's your last name?" Share it when the baby answers.
4. Teach the baby to show their age using fingers. Celebrate their efforts!
5. Encourage using both names when talking to the baby. Praise their participation.

Value of activity: Helps the child develop self-awareness and enables them to introduce themselves to new people.



36 MONTHS

Learning from Each Other

Materials: None

Steps:

1. Ask the baby, "What can you do at the park?"
2. Encourage them to demonstrate one activity like jumping or climbing.
3. Imitate the baby and appreciate how well they do it.
4. Share something that you like to do with the baby and invite them to imitate it.
5. Think about new and interesting things that you can teach each other

Value of activity: Helps the child feel more confident about their own interests and abilities and helps them learn something new with you.



Counting is Fun

Materials: 3 small objects (e.g., toys, blocks)

Steps:

1. Place three objects in front of the baby.
2. Point to each object and say, "Let's count together: one, two, three!"
3. Encourage the baby to touch each item while counting.
4. Repeat the counting exercise, celebrating their efforts.

Value of activity: Enhances cognitive abilities through counting and object recognition and develops early numeracy skills.



4.3 Adapting Activities for the Needs of Divyang Children (0-3 years)

The National Framework for Early Childhood Stimulation suggests a list of 140 activities for children from birth to three years, which cover holistic stimulation for the child’s cognitive, socio-emotional, language, physical, and creative development. However, to address developmental delays (for example, a child might take longer to walk or speak and might need help executing or developing fine motor skills or comprehending new information) and other disabilities (For instance, visual impairment, hearing impairment, down syndrome, or cerebral palsy), the suggested activities could be adapted based on the following principles:

- a. To practice what can be strengthened, eg. mouth muscles for speech delays
- b. To use a different sense in case of an impairment that cannot be fixed.

A multisensory approach, i.e. Visual Auditory Kinesthetic and Tactile (VAKT) can help with better learning. For example, use action rhymes, i.e. speaking (auditory) and doing hand and body movements (kinesthetic) at the same time. Teach a concept by showing pictures (visual), talking (auditory) and doing a related craft activity (tactile) with the hands. To teach patterns, use available objects like sticks and stones, toys, blocks, and then move on to paper-pencil tasks.

For example, Anganwadi workers use story books to read to the children, and engage their imagination. In case children are facing difficulties in understanding, go slower and follow the words with your finger. Include bright-coloured pictures for the hearing-impaired, and do voices for the visually-impaired. Use pictures, videos, and things to see for children who have trouble hearing. Eg: Pictures/photographs of parents, family members, great personalities, rare animals, plants, historical places, events etc. from newspapers, magazines, books etc. Use sound, like music or recordings, for children who can’t see well, like songs, rhymes, lullabies, radio, clapping, clicking, musical instruments etc.

1. Children with Developmental Delays

The Activity Calendar lists four activities for each month of a child’s age until 3 years. These activities

have been selected based on the developmental milestones a child is supposed to reach by that age. Some children, however, may take longer than expected to reach a milestone. This is termed as a ‘delay in development.’ To support children with delay caregivers can modify the activities according to the capacities of the child. This enables them to progress to the developmental milestone at their own pace. If a child is unable to perform the activity recommended for their age in the calendar, caregivers should choose activities recommended for younger children.

Example 1: At 14 months, a child may be unable to perform activities recommended for them in the activity calendar, such as Hide and Seek, due to their inability to walk without support.	Adaptation 1: The caregiver should, in such cases, pick up activities recommended for children aged six or seven months such as ‘Reaching out to the ball, In and Out etc.’ that only require the child to crawl, slowly building their ability to walk.
Example 2: At 20-25 months, a child who is unable to talk yet may not be able to take part in activities recommended for them in the calendar, such as ‘Talking on the phone.’	Adaptation 2: The caregiver should, in such cases, pick-up activities prescribed for a one-year-old child in the calendar, that only require them to return gestures. Examples would include Copying Actions, or Hide and Discover etc.

In addition, a caregiver must try to repeat the activity a number of times. Stay patient, and remain attentive to a child’s response while doing so. Give the child positive encouragement, and avoid taking out frustration on the child.

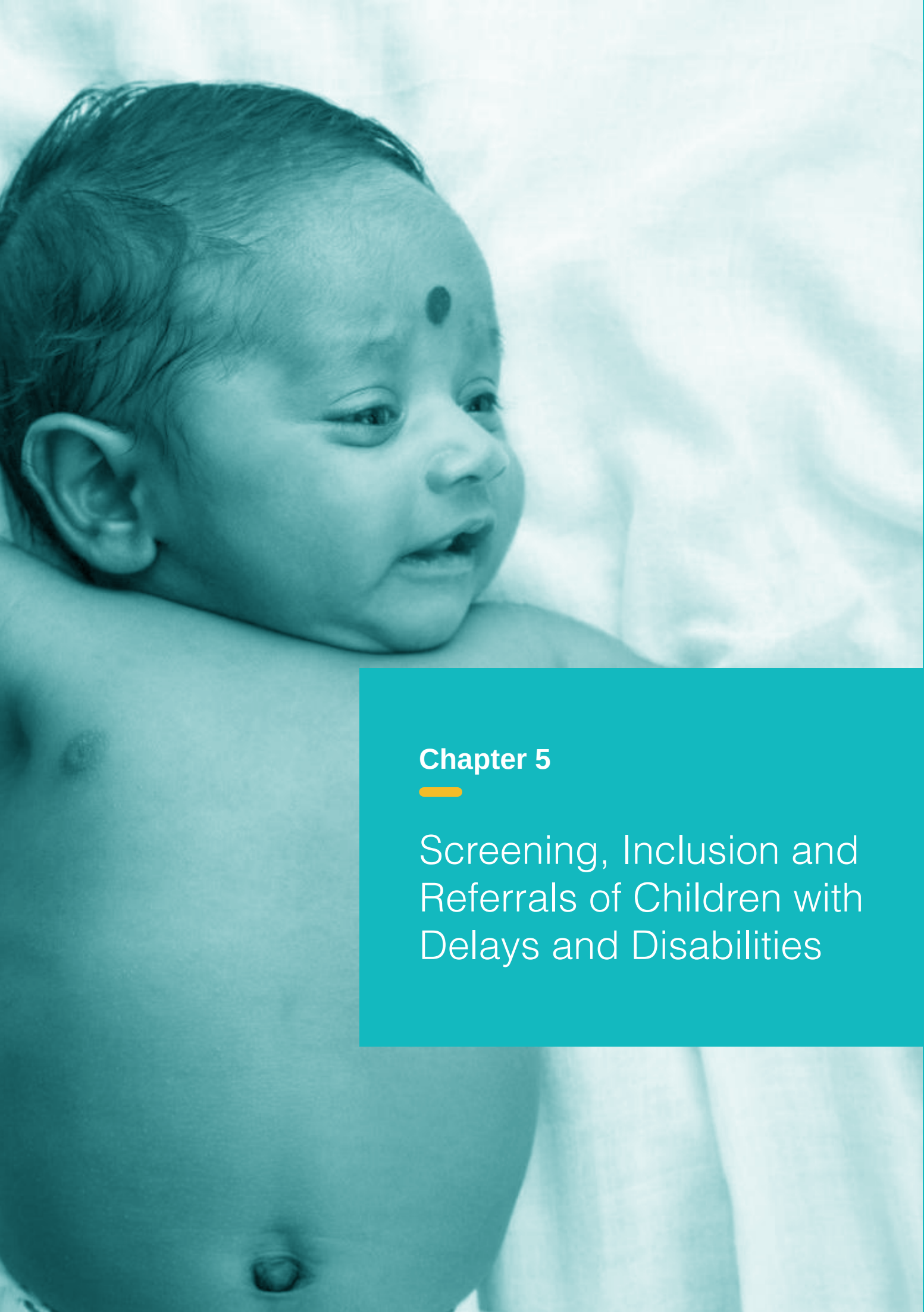
2. Children with Early Signs and Symptoms of Disabilities

In such cases, the activity can be modified to suit the child's abilities at any age. The modification ensures that the activity remains encouraging and enjoyable for the child, and contributes to their growth and development.

The table below lists some ways in which activities can be modified in line with different kinds of disabilities:

Type of Disability	Example of an existing activity	Suggested modification
Fine Motor	'Reaching out to the ball,' recommended for a 7-month old child.	The Anganwadi worker can use soft objects (like clay, spongy ball), for the child to hold and play with in order to improve hand functions
Vision Impairment	'Household Exploration,' recommended for a 12-month old child.	The caregiver can describe the house verbally, in as much detail as possible, to stimulate the child's remaining senses, and help them perceive their surroundings.
Hearing impairment	'Following Instructions,' recommended for a 14-month old child	The caregiver must repeat every instruction/step of the activity multiple times; while also teaching the child to lip-read in order for them to be able to follow what they're saying. Point to one's mouth and have the child watch the mouth movements.
Speech and Language Delays	'Pretend Play: Talking on the phone,' recommended for 25-month old child	Caregiver can begin the activity with some exercises to encourage the development of mouth muscles such as puckering, smiling widely, moving the tongue from side to side within the mouth, opening and closing the jaw, etc. While conducting the 'Pretend play: Talking on the phone' activity caregiver can use short sentences with fewer words, encourage the baby to observe caregiver speaking and to repeat the words slowly.
Intellectual and Developmental Delay	'Following Instructions,' recommended for a 16-month old child	A caregiver can break the instruction down into simple steps, providing the child with an easy process to follow. Caregiver should also demonstrate each step for the child enabling them to observe, imitate and learn. This will foster independence in the child.

Anganwadi workers play a critical role in supporting Children with Delays and Disabilities under the age of three years. The most critical and foundational aspect of this includes taking adequate measures during the prenatal, perinatal, and postnatal stages to prevent the development of disabilities in the child. One crucial way of doing this is by encouraging early childhood stimulation activities at home, with the parents, and at the Anganwadi centre or creche with the worker from birth to three. However, suppose a child is born with a disability or develops an impairment despite adequate care. In such a case, the community worker must follow the critical process of 'Screening-Inclusion-Referral' as outlined in the WCD Ministry's Divyang Protocol.



Chapter 5

Screening, Inclusion and Referrals of Children with Delays and Disabilities

Sometimes, a child may take longer than expected to develop particular abilities. For example, they might take longer to walk or speak and need help executing or developing fine motor skills and comprehending new information. Developmental delay refers to children who experience significant variation in the achievement of expected milestones for their actual or adjusted age. Delays can be temporary, and the child's development may catch up when the situation improves. However, if not cared for appropriately, these deviations in a child's developmental journey can compound to become a disability in the future.

The signs of a potential disability may not always be readily visible. For instance, visual impairment, hearing impairment, down syndrome, or cerebral palsy may be easily visible in a child. In contrast, learning disabilities such as speech delays, leading to literacy delays, may not be easily visible. Timely and regular screening by community workers as part of their home visits can make the delay or potential disability instantly known. This allows caregivers to routinely take stock of their child's growth and provide the necessary care.

With early detection of disabilities followed by practical curative steps, one can arrest future deterioration of the impairment. A child may either be born with or acquire a disability. However, in many cases, the early years go by with hardly any remedial stimulation or medical treatment to correct or reduce the impaired function. Research findings suggest that if detected early, almost one-third of impairments can be prevented from deteriorating through a few key inputs. Visual impairments such as squinting, visual defects, congenital cataracts, and hearing impairment can also be prevented from becoming severe with timely screening, referrals, and medical intervention.

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such a case, the community worker must follow the critical process of 'Screening-Inclusion-Referral' as outlined in the WCD Ministry's Divyang Protocol. In the upcoming sections, we will look closer at each of these stages and lay out a comprehensive set of guidelines to be followed by the Community Worker.



5.1 Early Developmental Milestones

Knowledge about developmental milestones is valuable since children with developmental disabilities may experience delays or difficulties achieving certain developmental milestones. For instance, they might experience difficulty with their gross motor skills, affecting their ability to crawl, walk, or run, or with their fine motor skills, making it challenging to perform tasks requiring precise hand movements, such as writing. Similarly, children with developmental disabilities may experience delays in achieving language milestones, such as

remembering or speaking fewer words, compared to other children their age.

Below is the list of developmental milestones for the child at varying intervals from the time of their birth till they turn three years of age. The milestones span the four critical development domains during the earliest years: cognitive skills, language skills, physical and motor skills, and social and emotional skills.

Stage	Developmental Milestones
At 3 months	• Begins to recognize the mother's face • Develops a social smile • Makes eye contact • Raises head at times when on tummy • Moves both arms and both legs when excited • Keep hands open and relaxed
At 6 months	• Keeps head steady when held upright and sits with support • Turns head toward the direction of sound • Attempts to reach and grasp an object • Laughs aloud or makes squealing sounds • Begins to babble "ah, ee, oo" other than when crying • Likes to look at oneself in a mirror
At 9 months	• Rolls over in both directions • Grasps a toy by using all fingers • Turns head to follow familiar faces or toys visually • Looks for toys that have been hidden in front of them • Responds to their name being called
At 12 months	• Sits without support and reach for toys without falling • Raises arms to be picked up • Crawls to get desired toys without bumping into any objects • Uses one or two common words in the mother tongue • Responds to simple requests like "no/ come here"

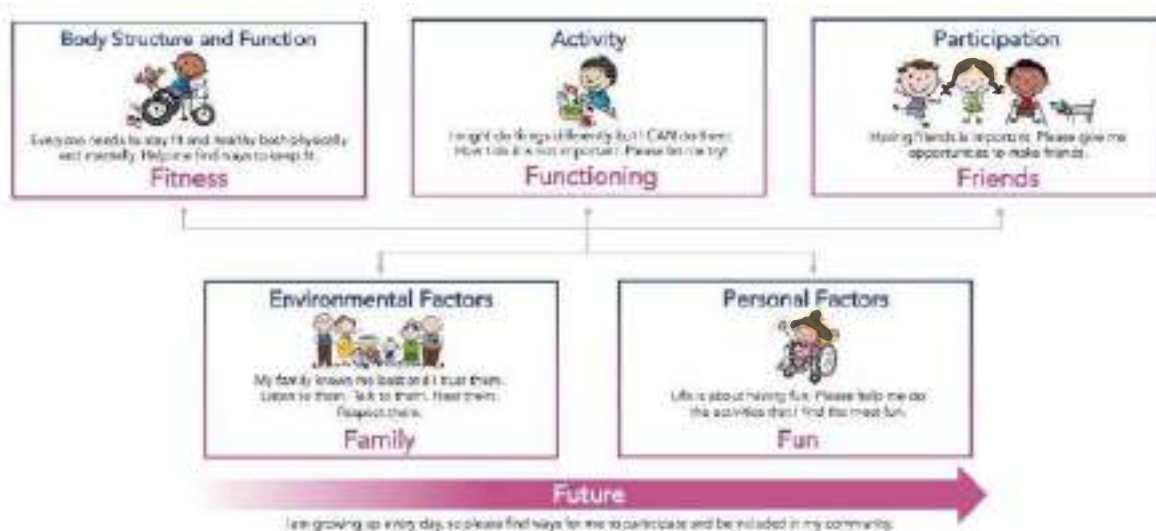
At 18 months	• Stands and takes several independent steps • Uses a variety of familiar gestures like waving, clapping, etc. • Puts pebbles/small objects in a container • Names and identifies common objects and their pictures in a book
At 24 months	• Walks steadily, even while pulling a toy • Imitates household chores • Correctly points out and names one or more body parts in person or in books
At 36 months	• Drinks from a cup without spilling • Names most familiar things consistently • Identifies colours and shapes • Makes a sentence by joining three or more words • Climbs up and down the stairs

5.2 Conducting Screenings for Early Detection

The Disability Screening Schedule (DSS) in the Annexure is a broad-based tool for screening disabilities in early childhood. Community workers can use the DSS to conduct a preliminary screening to identify ‘warning signs’ or ‘red flags’ of having a disability or being at risk of developing a disability through interactions with children under three years of age and their immediate caregivers, whether at home, at the Anganwadi centre, or in the creche. The DSS is not a diagnostic test and cannot be used to diagnose disability. If a child shows one or more of the warning signs detailed in it, then the steps for referral as per the Divyang Protocol must be followed.

5.3 Creating Inclusive Environments at home, at the creche and in the community

In the context of the early years, inclusion implies ensuring that each child has an equitable opportunity to participate in all learning processes - physical, cognitive, language, social, emotional, and creative, irrespective of their skills and abilities. In this section we will learn about a few key steps to be taken to ensure that children with disabilities feel seen and supported in their path to independence.



5.3.1 Inclusion at Home

For a child showing delays and disabilities, particularly until the age of three, care and inclusion must begin at home. Therefore, AWWs and ASHAs must immediately take up the task of sensitising the child's primary caregivers by making them aware that despite the child's specific disability, they can learn and grow with patience, care, and respect. The community worker should also support the caregiver in adopting specific measures to enable their child to gain independence and self-respect. Often, family members continue to perform all the tasks for the child with disabilities, limiting their opportunity to learn essential life skills. Outlined below is a simple and effective process for promoting independence in children with developmental delays or disabilities

Backward Chaining

Backward chaining refers to the process of breaking down the steps of a task and teaching them in reverse order. This gives the child an experience of success and completion with every attempt. Let's take a look at how this works:

Break down every day tasks into smaller steps	All but the last	Independently performing tasks
The caregiver starts by dividing a task into smaller steps. For example: The task of washing hands is broken down into the following smaller tasks. Going to sink > Opening tap/using mug > Wet hands > Use soap > Rub hands > Wet hands > Dry hands with towel	Initially the caregiver does all the steps for the child, except the last. For example: The caregiver does all the tasks except handing over the towel to the child to wipe and dry their hands Going to sink > Opening tap/using mug > Wet hands > Use soap > Rub hands > Wet hands > Dry hands with towel	Gradually reduce the number of steps performed by the parent. For example: Slowly and gradually the caregiver reduces the number of steps they do until the child is slowly able to do all the steps on their own Going to sink > Opening tap/using mug > Wet hands > Use soap > Rub hands > Wet hands > Dry hands with towel

NOTE:

- Activity can be divided into 7-10 manageable steps.
- The steps divided need to be done consistently in precisely the same way.
- Each chain takes time to learn depending on their ability. It is essential to be patient and allow the child to repeat the instructions.

Examples for how children with specific disabilities can be supported in their learning journey

Hearing Disabilities

- Encourage lipreading
- Get the child's attention before you speak to them
- Repeat words and instructions slowly and many times

Visual Disabilities

- Help children use their other senses to make sense of their world and learn and play.
- Describe environment and things in it
- Remove hazards from the physical environment

Speech and Language Delays

- Talking clearly and slowly
- Encouraging the child
- Using more actions and gestures while talking
- While sharing important information, cut down on extra words

Physical Disabilities: Difficulties with Fine Motor Skills

- Provide the child with we clay to hold and press in different ways to improve hand functions
- Provide the child with a spongy ball to press and release to improve hand functions

5.3.2 Designing Creches for Inclusion

The creche should be designed with the universal design principle in mind, whereby making a structure accessible for one helps it become accessible to all. They must include corners and arenas where children at varying developmental levels can play and stimulate themselves. A particular focus of the creches could be on spatial stimulation, as they can use the physical space available to them to help a child learn using inventive methods.

The caregiver in the creche should follow the same principles outlined in the responsive caregiving framework, pay close attention to the child, and respond in accordance.

5.3.3 Community Approach towards Children with Developmental Delays

The community members around a child must also play their part in creating a healthy and stigma-free environment for their growth. In order to do so, they can create support groups and networks for parents and caregivers of Divyang children. These groups can provide emotional support, share resources, and exchange information on best practices. The members should also participate actively in community-based events, like VHSNDs, ECCE Days, etc., to support Divyang children and their families—and encourage all children to play together with kindness.

More importantly, a member of the community should encourage acceptance and support for Divyang children within the community and not resort to the usage of any labels or hurtful slurs. In their interactions with the elderly and the young, they must promote the understanding that diversity is a strength, that every child has unique abilities and potential, and the right to a fulfilling life.

5.4 Referral of children showing developmental delays as per the Screening Test

As per the Divyang Protocol, if children are consistently not meeting their milestones, or there are visible signs and symptoms of disabilities, the community worker should support the parents and families in accessing support through referrals.

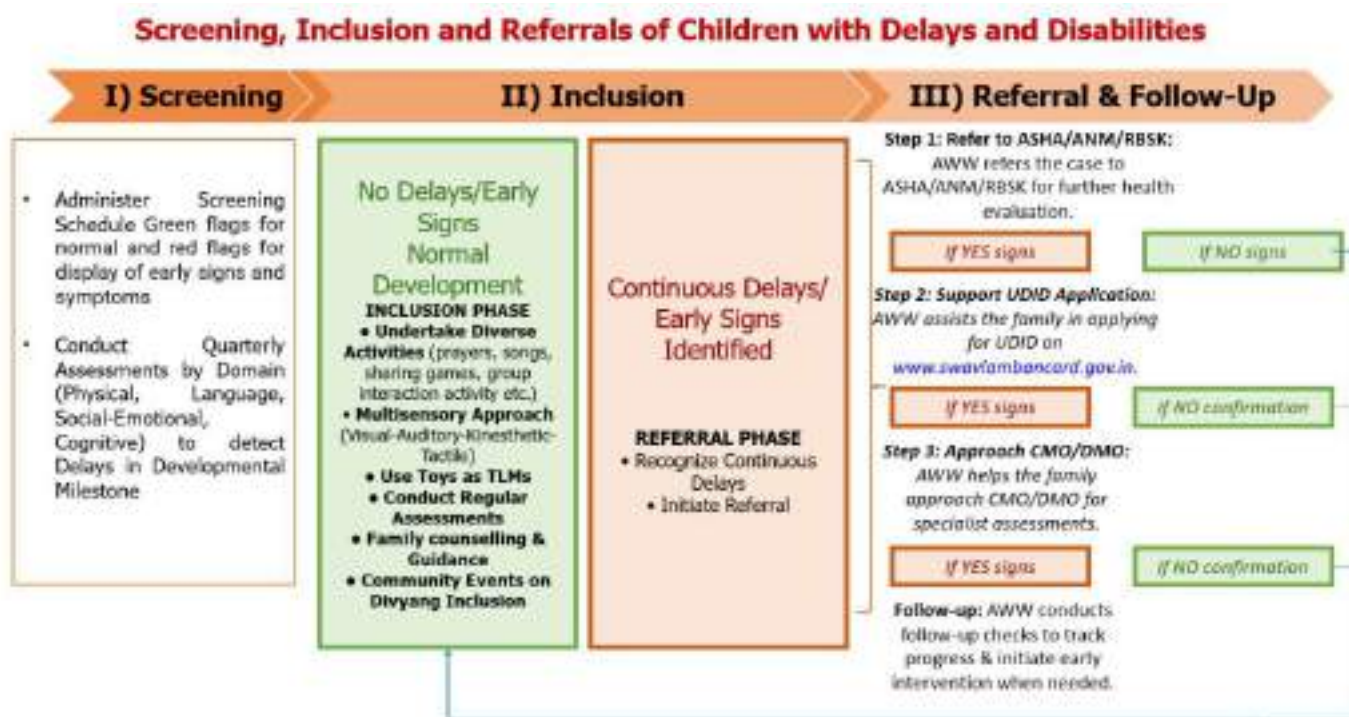
Three Steps for Referral:

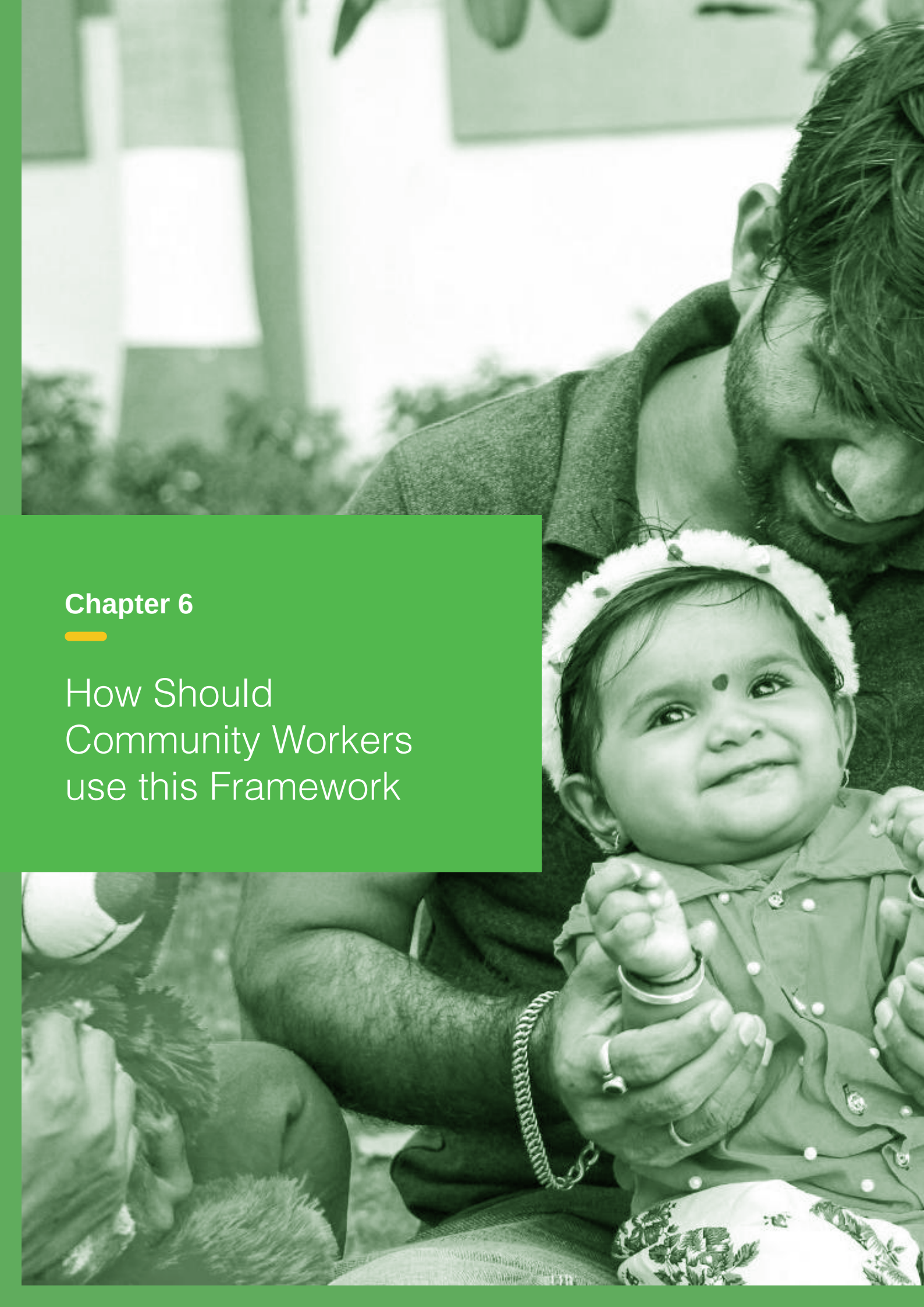
a. Refer to ASHA/ANM to determine and assist in escalation to Primary Health Centre.

b. Support family to apply on www.swavlambancard.gov.in for UDID and Disability Certificate. It can be issued by home district hospitals as well as the hospital where the PWD is taking medical treatment, as per RPWD Act 2016.

c. Support family in approaching Chief Medical Officer (CMO) or District Medical Officer (DMO) for verification and assignment of specialists for assessment. After the Medical Board decision, the card is dispatched to the family via Speed Post.

Flow Chart for Screening, Referral and Inclusion of Divyang Children



A photograph of a man with a beard and long hair, wearing a dark jacket, holding a baby. The baby is wearing a white headband with a pom-pom and a dark jacket. The man is looking down at the baby with a smile. The background is blurred, showing some foliage and a building.

Chapter 6

How Should Community Workers use this Framework

Community workers can influence childcare through three key channels: at home, at the Anganwadi centre or creche, and at community-based events.

6.1 Caregiver Guidance for Early Stimulation

6.1.1 Avenues for Providing Guidance to Caregivers on Early Childhood Stimulation

During Home Visits

Anganwadi workers and ASHAs frequently conduct home visits to families, mothers, and young children within the communities they serve. In Saksham Anganwadi and Mission Poshan 2.0 guidelines, it is mentioned that 18 home visits must be undertaken, for mothers or until the child is of 2 years of age.

- 4 visits are prescribed for pregnant women
- 9 visits while the child is between 0 and 6 months of age
- 9 more visits between the ages of 6 months and 2 years

During regular monthly meetings at the creche/ centre

- Mothers also visit Anganwadi centres to conduct height and weight assessments for the child up to the age of six years, every month. In addition, mothers often come to the Anganwadi Centre at different frequencies to receive their Take Home Rations as a form of supplementary nutrition.

Through community events

- The Anganwadi worker, during community-based events (CBEs) under Mission Poshan 2.0 and village health sanitation and nutrition days (VHSNDs), may also take up effective information, education and communication activities around early stimulation with local decision-makers and wider community. CBEs are mandatory to be organized twice per month at every Anganwadi Centre, and ramped up during Poshan Maah and Poshan Pakhwada. Members of Bal Vikas Samiti, community leaders, Panchayat members, Self Help Groups and other women's groups, local NGOs, administrative personnel, especially at district and block levels (ICDS, WCD, Health, Education, Child Protection, Rehabilitation, Disability etc.) may be invited

6.1.2 Guidelines for Providing Guidance to Caregivers on Early Childhood Stimulation

1. Provide tailored Guidance to Parents and Caregivers: Anganwadi workers and ASHA's can utilise the Monthly Stimulation Plans to cross-check the appropriate session plan based on each child's age and abilities. They can further use this document as a reference to guide discussions with parents on responsive caregiving practices and play-based activities tailored to each child's age and abilities.

2. Monitor children's growth and provide counselling to parents: The framework entails a comprehensive pool of developmental milestones and a screening schedule. AWWs and ASHA's can use the schedule to check if the child is developing at the expected pace and if any delay warrants attention or intimation to parents.

3. Create awareness about better child care in the community through mothers' meetings: The framework describes how to adopt a responsive caregiving approach towards children in their first three years. The creche worker can share and discuss the same with the parents and help them become responsive caregivers.

Sample Guidelines for preparing for the home visit

- **Step 1: Identify the age of the child**
- **Step 2: Refer to the stimulation activity calendar to identify activities to be conducted as per the child's age.** Eg: If the child is between 10 and 11 months of age then refer to activities mentioned in month 10 of the stimulation activity calendar.
- **Step 3: Prepare the teaching-learning-material required to conduct any of the activities.**
Eg: If the activity involves
- **Step 4: Identify any one or two caregiving behaviours to emphasise during the home-visit.**

Home-visit Guide Sample

Child's age: 6-8 months

Skills/Topic: Lip Lessons and Where's the Toy

Duration: 45 minutes

Catch up and Review | 10 minutes

Well-being questions

Inquire about baby's health

Review previous visit



Language Activity: Lip Lessons | 12 mins

Say,

Today's first activity is called 'Lip Lessons'.

Demonstration

Step 1: If the parents and baby are comfortable and happy in your presence, find a place to sit next to the baby. Now talk to the baby until they start making some sounds of their own.

Step 2: Imitate the baby's sounds. "Aa, ss, oooo, eee, bb bb" Make eye contact with the baby as you are doing this, smile and observe how the baby reacts.

Step 3: Now slowly move your face closer to the baby and place their hand on your mouth as you are making the sounds. Repeat this with the baby a few times trying out different sounds each time.

Explaining the Importance

You must also tell them why this activity is important. "Listening to new sounds, playing with sounds by repeating them and touching the mouth while making sounds cultivates the child's interest in listening and communicating. The baby will also start to understand the relationship between listening and speaking. Small sound activities like these starting at this age will improve the baby's chances of communicating confidently with others as they get older."

Setting Expectations

Explain to the family that this activity can be done repeatedly “If the baby looks playful and is making sounds then join them in playing with sounds! You can do this when you are getting the baby ready after their bath, or when the family gathers together in the evening you can involve the baby in the conversation. Do this every day if you can - mumma can do it, papa can do, grandma can do it. Everyone can do it!”

Play Activity: Where’s the Toy | 12 mins

Say,
Today’s first activity is called ‘Where’s the Toy’.

Demonstration

Step 1: Show the object to the baby and talk to them about it. “Look at this? What is it? It’s a spoon.

Step 2: Make sure that you are making eye contact with the baby and smiling at them as you are doing this. If the baby reaches out for the object, then let them have it. If not then try with another object. Let the baby play with the object.

Step 3: Now gently try to take back the object and place it under a cloth as they are watching. Point to the cloth and ask the baby “Where is the spoon?” Hold them carefully as they try to touch the cloth and find the object. Talk to the baby and praise them for their efforts! “Very nice baby! Did you figure out that the spoon is under the cloth?”

Explaining the Importance

Now you can tell them why this activity is important. “This activity is like a fun puzzle for the baby’s brain. The baby will start to understand that objects are present even when you can’t see them directly. They will use their sense of touch, their eyes, their ears, everything to find the hidden object. All of this will improve their cognitive abilities!”

Setting Expectations

Explain to the family that this activity can be done repeatedly “You can do this activity with the baby whenever you find them in a playful mood. This can be a great bonding activity for the baby and all their caregivers! Do this every day if you can and remember mumma can do it, papa can do, grandpa can do it. Everyone can do it!”

Parenting Tip | 6 minutes

Now is a great time to draw parent's attention to the parenting tip of the day. "Did you notice how every time I was playing with the baby I was making eye contact and smiling at them? Doing this makes the baby feel special and safe when they are interacting with you. It shows them that you care about them and that you are paying attention to them! So remember to do this at least a few times every day - and if all of the baby's caregivers show them that you care, the baby will grow up secure and confident."

Recap, Reinforce, Encourage | 5 minutes

Wrap up the home visit by informing the parents about the next visit.

- **Reinforce:** "See you next month with new toys and games. I hope to hear that you have been doing the activities and making eye contact with the baby."
- **Encourage:** "The baby is so lucky to have such lovely caregivers!"

6.2 Childcare and Stimulation at the Centre/Creche

In addition, creche workers, whether at an Anganwadi-cum-creche or standalone creche, provide essential child-care services, enabling a large number of women to enter the workforce, improving the family's financial stability, and ensuring children receive the best possible access to healthcare and education in the future. Recognizing and leveraging these community workers' vital roles as trusted figures this Framework serves as a guide and companion to support their existing efforts. Specifically designed to emphasise early childhood stimulation, the Framework becomes a comprehensive cornerstone in the programmatic interventions.

6.2.1. Guidelines for Childcare and Stimulation at the Center/ Creche

As outlined in the Standard Operating Procedure for Palna scheme, released in 2023, any creche worker responsible for the caregiving of children below three should facilitate the child's overall development, providing nurturing care and age-appropriate cognitive stimulation. In line with the mandates, the framework can help creche workers perform the below tasks:

1. Organise stimulation activities for children below three years: Creche workers can use the activity calendar in the framework to organise the stimulation activities for the children under their watch. The calendar lists the play materials required for each activity, which can be procured or created by the creche worker.

2. Monitor children's development and provide counselling to parents: The framework entails a comprehensive pool of developmental milestones and a screening schedule. The creche worker can use the screening schedule to keep track of each



6.2.2 Parental Guidance

1. Provide tailored Guidance to Parents and Caregivers: Anganwadi workers and ASHA's can utilise the Monthly Stimulation Plans to cross-check the appropriate session plan based on each child's age and abilities. They can further use this document as a reference to guide discussions with parents on responsive caregiving practices and play-based activities tailored to each child's age and abilities

2. Monitor children's growth and provide counselling to parents: The framework entails a comprehensive pool of developmental milestones and a screening schedule. AWWWS and ASHA's can use the schedule to check if the child is developing at the expected pace and if any delay warrants attention or intimation to parents.

3. Create awareness about better child care in the community through mothers' meetings: The framework describes how to adopt a responsive caregiving approach towards children in their first three years. The creche worker can share and discuss the same with the parents and help them become responsive caregivers.



Chapter 7

Creating a Supportive Environment

7.1 Enabling and Empowering Community Workers

Anganwadi workers, ASHAs, and Creche workers perform critical roles by supporting parents and families in child care or providing supplementary childcare services. Therefore, regular and meaningful training for community workers is essential to ensure that stimulation programs are implemented with care and efficiency. There are various channels through which the necessary knowledge, mindsets, and skills can be disseminated. In the following section, we will look at some of these channels.

1. Anganwadi Worker Training under ‘Poshan Bhi Padhai Bhi’: A critical aspect of the Poshan Bhi Padhai Bhi Program is to highlight the importance of education and stimulation along with critical aspects of health and nutrition. CDPO, Supervisor, and Anganwadi Worker training conducted as part of the program provide a perfect opportunity to highlight the importance of the first three years in developing the child’s brain and to solidify the Anganwadi worker’s role in supporting children’s cognitive stimulation through home visits and caregiver counselling.

2. Distribution of digital and print resources: Beautifully designed digital and print material such as the Stimulation Activity Calendar and posters on Responsive Caregiving, Serve and Return, Talk-Play-Love, Positive Guidance, and more should be made available to community workers to refer to on their smartphones and display in their respective centres or creches. Resources that use simple language, culturally diverse and attractive illustrations, and practical instructional design can increase the adoption of good practices. The use of extensive information, education, and communication (IEC) material is recommended by the ECCE Task Force, such as:

- a. Demonstrations of play activities for babies and toddlers
- b. Pictorial poster exhibitions of an interactive nature, with prime messages on holistic child care, with volunteers helping to interpret and discuss
- c. Demonstration of nutritious local recipes

- d. Quizzes related to information on holistic child care
- e. Corner for making playthings out of waste or inexpensive material

- f. Street skits delivering prime messages in the local idiom

- g. Short films, followed by Q &A sessions

3. Creating an environment of inclusivity: All community workers should be trained on the specific measures that are part of the Divyang or Disability Protocol. Simultaneously, treating all community workers with care and respect, irrespective of their backgrounds, can incentivize them to become champions of inclusivity in the communities with whom they interact. Convergence with DEPWD can assist children with screening and access to Swavlamban Card.

4. Digital Applications such as the Poshan Tracker App: Digital Applications such as the Poshan Tracker App provide a unique opportunity to provide end-to-end support to community workers through consistent and up-to-date resources, guidelines, and instructions. Convergence with the Health Ministry for Paalan 1000 app can assist in stimulation.

5. Budgetary provisions: Budgetary provisions for stimulation and play material have been made under Saksham Anganwadi and Palna scheme guidelines. Indigenous toys, age-appropriate materials, infrastructure upgradation as necessary, etc. will support community workers in delivering high-quality early childhood stimulation. For stimulating the creative, social, emotional, cognitive, and intellectual development of children under six years of age in convergence with education development programmes, Saksham Anganwadi provides for more services with better infrastructure, including internet/wifi connectivity, LED screens, water purifier/ installation of RO machine and Early Childhood Care and Education with smart learning aids, audio-visual aids, child-friendly learning equipment and artwork (educational painting, practice board for children, information board), etc.

6. State-specific provisions: States have taken extensive action, as referred to in Section 1.3, can

also create a supportive environment for community workers.

7.2 Role of Parents, Family and Community

Ensuring a child's well-rounded development is the collective prerogative of the adults around them, from the parents and immediate family members to the neighbourhood and community. This is especially true in a country like India, where children are raised with a strong sense of community, eating and playing in their neighbours' homes and guided by the wisdom of all the community elders. Therefore, it is essential for all these primary and secondary caregivers to become aware of their roles and to play their part in child care responsibly.

Role of Parents: Historically, the burden of childcare, both in India and globally, has rested on women's shoulders. Women often perform tasks such as feeding, bathing, and putting the child to sleep, with male family members earning an income, taking the child outside the home, and purchasing toys and other materials from the market. However, the earliest years of a child's life are the most impressionable, and this is an excellent time for parents to adopt gender-neutral parenting practices such as sharing care work equitably and de-emphasizing gender-specific approaches in parent-child interactions. Such practices will ensure that both caregivers are well supported and that children of all genders experience physical and emotional safety and balance.

Role of Family: Outside the parents, family members such as grandparents, aunts and uncles, and siblings play the most crucial role in childcare. In situations where several family members live together in one home or near each other, extended family members can support in myriad ways, such as taking up household chores typically performed by the parent, especially in the months following childbirth, having positive and playful interactions with the child and facilitating everyday childcare tasks when required. This kind of support improves a child's chances of success by fostering several different wonderful relationships; it also eases the stress experienced by the parents, enabling them to provide better childcare.

Role of Community: Everyone in the community is responsible for making it a safe and positive environment in which a child can blossom and grow. Adverse Childhood Experiences in the home and community like domestic violence, sexual violence, substance abuse etc. negatively impact the child's cognitive and emotional development. Modelling gender equality, including women's safety and empowerment, in the home and community is critical for the child to develop a balanced and equitable mindset. The overall national context of improving female literacy and labour force participation contributes to this trend. All members of the community can keep a watchful eye on the child and their caregiver and support them in any way possible. The community can also designate spaces for young children to gather and play with each other. Apart from providing the child with opportunities for safe social interaction, such spaces can also enable the exchange of ideas and practices among their caregivers. Widespread mass media campaigns should be undertaken country-wide, with celebrity campaigners, digital, print and radio, audiovisual materials, competitions, slogans, jingles, music etc.



7.3 Leveraging Technology for Innovation

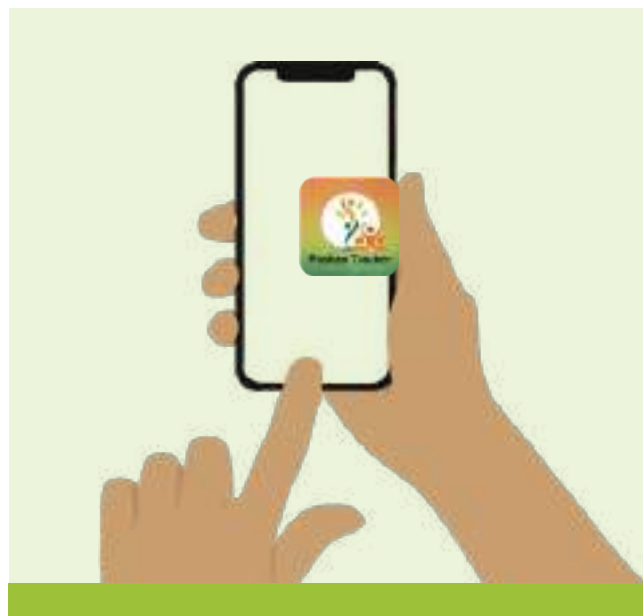
In an era marked by a surge in digital connectivity and technological awakening in India, there is a unique and valuable opportunity to enhance the quality and accessibility of early childhood development through strategic technological interventions. As per Telecom Regulatory Authority of India data of November 2023, India has over 880 million internet users. The widespread digital penetration and increased technological literacy provide an ideal backdrop for integrating technology into the domain of early childhood stimulation and development. Some ideas that can be taken up are as follows:

1. Messaging Apps for Knowledge Sharing: A substantial portion of India's households use WhatsApp and other messaging for communication. Messaging platforms can therefore be utilised for sharing various digital materials in text, image, audio, and video format at a relatively low cost across the country. The platforms allow for one-on-one interactions, making it possible to offer targeted communication as per the child or caregiver's needs. On the other hand, functions like WhatsApp groups can be used to create a self-sustained community of learners who can support each other through similar experiences. This real-time communication platform, therefore, serves as a conduit for the seamless exchange of educational insights, empowering parents with the knowledge and understanding necessary for fostering optimal child learning.

2. Poshan Tracker App Integration for Anganwadi Workers

Integrating a comprehensive repository of activities, milestones, checklists, and other resources into the Poshan Tracker app is essential to empowering Anganwadi workers and streamlining information dissemination. This centralised digital hub ensures efficient communication and equips workers with the necessary resources to stimulate children effectively, monitor their growth and development and screen them for developmental delays and early signs of disabilities.

3. Inclusive Technology for Children with Disabilities: In pursuing inclusive early childhood development, technology can bridge learning gaps for children with disabilities. Young organisations and start-ups increasingly offer multisensory tools designed explicitly for visually and audibly impaired children. By combining a smartphone camera,



voice recorders, and various digital applications, technology can help learners interpret the world regardless of sensory disabilities.

Integrating technology into early childhood development is a promising avenue for enriching learning experiences. Leveraging tools such as QR codes, app integrations, inclusive technologies, and other upcoming innovations such as Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning (AI & ML) aligns with today's digital reality. It maximises the potential for optimal learning and development in children during their earliest years. Through such thoughtful integration, we can ensure that technology becomes an inclusive force, fostering a more empowered society where every child has the opportunity to thrive.

Annexures



Annexures

Annexure I: Internal Committee on the National Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) Curriculum, 2024

Ministry of Women and Child Development

Internal Committee on the National Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) Curriculum, 2024

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, with its vision of universal access to early childhood care and education (ECCE), highlights the need for an evolved curriculum for the foundational stage of learning from 3-8 years. It provides an opportunity to strengthen the entire framework of ECCE in Anganwadis in alignment with the National Curriculum Framework for Foundational Stage (NCF-FS) 2022. The policy recommends that children would attend ECCE programs in Anganwadi centres (located in the community or co-located with schools), pre-primary classes in schools (government or private), and standalone pre-schools.

The Ministry of Women and Child Development (MWCD) has developed the National ECCE Curriculum Framework (2013), Quality Standards for ECCE, and a national prototype for a pre-school kit, age-appropriate workbooks and child assessment cards (2017). These resources were shared with all States/UTs for contextualization and implementation at all Anganwadi Centres (AWCs). Many States/UTs have developed and finalized their annual contextualized ECCE curriculum based on the 2013 National ECCE Curriculum released by MWCD.

As per the recommendations of the ECCE Task Force constituted by MWCD in March 2022, the existing National ECCE Curriculum Framework 2013 needs to be reviewed in light of NEP, 2020 and NCF-FS, 2022. The National Institute of Public Cooperation and Child Development (NIPCCD) has been entrusted with this responsibility.

To ensure the creation of a holistic curriculum, an Internal Committee has been constituted.

The objective of this committee is to draft a holistic curriculum for early childhood care and education (3-6 years) and early stimulation (0-3 years) which

integrates the National ECCE Curriculum 2013 with NCF-FS, best practices from States Curriculum documents, latest science on child development, and the needs of Divyang Children. The curriculum should be practically implemented by States and Anganwadi functionaries.

The curriculum will contain the following key features:

1. Catering to the complete Early Childhood Continuum: Addressing critical stages from birth to six years old, the document will serve as a contextual guide for Anganwadi Workers based on Indian and international ECCE research and pedagogical practices. It will emphasize age-appropriate, stimulation activities and responsive caregiving suggestions for ages 0-3. 0-3 years stimulation is being covered for the first time. For 3 to 6-year-olds, the curriculum will introduce competency-based lesson plans and a monthly thematic approach.

2. Aligned with NCF-FS: The ECCE curriculum will cover all domains of learning, aligning seamlessly with the goals and competencies outlined in NCF-FS.

3. Aligned with State Curriculum Documents: Monthly themes, daily structure, competency progression and activity suggestions shall be incorporated after carefully studying at least 15 state curriculum documents, including Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Meghalaya, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, Chandigarh, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Delhi, Punjab, Kashmir, Nagaland, Tamil Nadu and Telangana.

4. Stimulation Activities: For ages 0 to 3 years, the curriculum shall detail stimulation activities and provide a robust communication plan for Anganwadi teachers on educating and including caregivers at

home. This will enable them to engage in structured, holistic and age-appropriate child development stimulation activities at home.

5. Lesson Plans for Daily Use: For ages 3 to 6, the curriculum shall introduce detailed competency-based lesson plans, together with a monthly thematic approach for Anganwadis, fostering engaging and enriching environments. The daily (4 hour schedule), weekly (6 days) and monthly lesson plans shall detail out specific activities with gender and disability inclusion nuances, suggested toys and Teaching Learning Material, activity variations catering to diverse age and capacity/skill set of children in the

centre. Lesson plans shall be designed ensuring sufficient time and flexibility to monitor learning pace, reinforce, repeat and revisit key learning outcomes to strengthen them.

6. Continuous and Comprehensive Evaluation (CCE) and robust assessment: The curriculum shall provide comprehensive tools including worksheets, checklists for weekly, monthly and quarterly observation and assessment of children. Observation and assessment helps to ensure careful understanding of the development and learning trajectory of each child, aligned to specific competencies and learning outcomes.

Constitution of the Internal Committee to finalize the National Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) Curriculum Framework, 2024, MWCD		
Sl. No.	Name	Designation
1.	Prof. Venita Kaul, Professor Emerita, Ambedkar University- Delhi	Chairperson
2.	Ms. Tripti Gurha, Joint Secretary (MWCD) & Director (NIPCCD)	Member
3.	Dr. Shubhra Chatterjee, Director, Vikramshila Education Centre	Member
4.	Ms. Sunisha Ahuja, Education Specialist	Member
5.	Dr. Reetu Chandra, Deputy Secretary (ECCE & FLN Policy), MoE	Member
6.	Dr. Vibha Krishnamurthy, Ummeed	Member
7.	Prof. Suniti Sanwal, Child Development Department of Elementary Education, NCERT	Member
8.	Dr. Shobhna Gupta, Deputy Commissioner and In-charge (Child Health & RBSK), MoHFW	Member
9.	Ms. Namya Mahajan, Co-Founder, Rocket Learning	Member
10.	Ms. Jyotika, Deputy Secretary, MWCD	Member
11.	Dr. Geeta Chopra, Professor, Institute of Home Economics, University of Delhi	Member
12.	Dr. Rita Patnaik, Joint Director, NIPCCD	Member Secretary

In order to synthesize the document, based on the valuable recommendations of the Internal Committee Members, a Working Group was constituted comprising of Dr. Rita Patnaik from NIPCCD, and Ms. Vibha Iyer, Ms. Sanjana Manaktala, and Ms. Sukhna Sawhney from Rocket Learning.

Annexure II: Disability Screening Schedule (DSS)

PLEASE NOTE: The Disability Screening Schedule (DSS) is a broad based screening tool for screening of disabilities in early childhood years. The DSS can be used by community workers including Anganwadi Workers, Creche workers or ASHA's for preliminary screening for identification of 'warning signs' or 'red flags' of having a disability or of being 'at risk' of developing a disability. DSS is not meant to diagnose disability or disease as it is not a diagnostic test. In case a child shows one or more of the warning signs detailed in it, the child should be referred to PHC/CMO/DEIC/Rehabilitation Practitioners for proper diagnosis and intervention.

Instructions:

1. AWW can administer this easy-to-use checklist to all children under six year
2. The checklist aims to identify early warning signs of delay or deviance in development
3. If the child screened by the community worker shows any 'warning signs'/ early signs of disability/ red flags in development, then the steps for referral as per the Divyang Protocol must be followed.
4. The AWW must remain in touch with the family of this child and must follow up on the actions taken by the parents.

Information about the child

1. Name of the child:
2. Mother's name:
3. Father's name:
4. Address:
5. Gender of the child:
 - a. Boy
 - b. Girl
6. Date of Birth:
7. Age of Child:
 - a. 0-3 months
 - b. 3-6 months
 - c. 6-12 months
 - d. 1-2 Years
 - e. 2-3 Years
 - f. 3-4 Yrs
 - g. 4-5 Yrs
 - h. 5-6 Yrs

Part A: Please ask the following from the parent/observe in child and fill the response

Sl. No.	Question	Yes/ No	Comments
1.	Did you experience any complications during your pregnancy? For example, high blood pressure, diabetes, anemia, or diseases like measles, mumps, or rubella?		If the answer to any of these questions is yes, the child should be watched carefully as they are at risk of having a disability.
2.	Did you experience any of the following complications during childbirth? For example: Very long delivery, Surgery, Forceps delivery, Premature delivery, Baby was born with low birth weight		
3.	Did the child have any problems at birth or soon after? For example, delayed birth cry, jaundice, blueness, or high fever.		
4.	Was the color of the child unusual at birth? (Blue /Yellow /Pale)		
5.	Did the child have feeding difficulties such as suckling or swallowing during mother's feeding?		
6.	Has the child ever had fits or lost consciousness since birth?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
7.	Do the child's eyes frequently turn red or water?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
8.	Is there frequent pus or watery discharge from the child's ears?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
9.	Does the child frequently complain about ear aches or headaches?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.

10.	Does the child have any missing or deformed body parts?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
11.	Is the child too small or too weak compared to other children of similar age?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
12	Does the child's body have uncoordinated or jerky movements, or does the child have poor balance while walking?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
13..	Does the child walk with a limp?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
14.	Can the child not walk, or did the child start walking much later than other children?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
15.	Is there a lump or bump on the child's backbone?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
16.	Do the child's eyes squint?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
17.	Are the pupils of the child's eyes gray or white?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
18.	Does the child often bang into objects while walking, or do they fall frequently? Do they have difficulty seeing at night?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.

19.	Are the child's ears deformed or missing?		If yes, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
20.	Move any object, such as a toy or a pen, about 12-20 inches in front of the child. Move it around within their visual field. Does the child move their head with the movement of the object?		If the child cannot visually track the object, this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.
21.	Take a rattle/ bell/ utensil about 1-3 feet from the child's ear. Be careful that the child is not looking toward you. Now, make a sound by shaking/banging the object. Does the child turn their head toward the source of the sound?		If the child doesn't turn their head toward the source of the sound then this is a red flag or warning sign. Please refer the child for diagnosis and treatment.

PART B: Age-specific milestones

If a delay is observed by the worker or reported by parents, the child should be referred to a health facility or rehabilitation center for early diagnosis and early intervention

Sr. No.	Milestone	Time by which it should be achieved	Achieved /Delayed
1.	No big smiles or other warm, joyful expressions	by 6 months	
2.	Supports one own neck		
3.	Turns over belly to back and back to belly	by 7-8 months	
4.	Sits without support	by 9 months	
5.	Provides back-and-forth responses with sounds, smiles, or other facial expressions		
6.	Makes babbling sounds like 'ba ba' 'ma ma' 'da da'	By 12 months	

Sr. No.	Milestone	Time by which it should be achieved	Achieved /Delayed
7.	Responds to own name	By 12 months	
8.	Does back-and-forth gestures such as pointing, showing, reaching or waving		
9.	Speaks a few words	By 16 months	
10.	Walks without support	By 18 months	
11.	Follow the instructions when asked to do something, like 'come here' or 'give me the glass'	By 18 months	
12.	Speaks a few words	By 24 months	
13.	Can say own name	By 3 years	
14.	Achieve toilet control	By 4 years	
15.	Avoids simple hazards	By 4 years	
16.	Eats by themselves	By 4 years	
17.	Dresses up on their own	By 5 years	

Annexure III: Roles and Responsibilities

This document is designed to support the Anganwadi System, ASHA workers, Creche workers and any other frontline workers, as well as parents and caregivers, dealing with children under the age of 3 years.

1. For Anganwadi Workers, ASHA Workers, Creche Workers:

a. The month-wise stimulation activities may be carried out by Anganwadi and ASHA Workers during the scheduled home visits for children under the age of 2 years. They may further be carried during growth monitoring, i.e. weighing of the infants, as well as when mothers interact with the Anganwadi worker to receive her Take Home Rations. Finally, they can also be used in the Anganwadi Centre, in States where expanded hours and creche facilities are being provided.

b. Creche workers under the Palna scheme can use these activities on a regular basis with the children under their care.

c. ASHA workers may also use these month-wise activities and also administer the screening schedule for Divyang children to increase knowledge of caregivers regarding their child's developmental milestones.

d. Screening (developmental delays and early signs of disability) and referrals may be tracked via Poshan Tracker.

2. For Supervisors:

a. Theoretical sections of the present framework can be scanned for a general understanding of early child development and responsive caregiving.

b. Monthly Activities in the Framework can be provided to AWWs who are unable to access them on their own.

c. During supportive supervision and review meetings, it can be checked whether the monthly activities and Divyang screening schedules are being followed. AWWs may be encouraged to follow the activities provided.

d. Community-based events can be organized around activity demonstration sessions, parenting guidance, stimulation and importance of ECD.

3. For CDPOs:

a. Theoretical sections of the present framework can be scanned for a general understanding of early child development and responsive caregiving.

b. Monthly Activities in the Framework can be provided to Supervisors who are unable to access them on their own.

c. During supportive supervision and review meetings, it can be checked whether the monthly activities and Divyang screening schedules are being followed. Supervisors may be encouraged to convey and support AWWs in delivery of in-centre care and home visit guidance.

d. Additional resource persons in the Block may be identified to support and train AWWs, such as nursery teacher training institutes, non-profit organizations, private daycare centres, Balvatikas, other government or private pre-primary schools or teachers, interested and experienced individuals, community leaders etc.

4. For DPOs and District Officials:

a. Theoretical sections of the present framework can be scanned for a general understanding of early child development and responsive caregiving.

b. Monthly Activities in the Framework can be provided to CDPOs, who are unable to access them on their own.

c. During review meetings including in the District Nutrition Committees, it can be checked whether the monthly activities and Divyang screening schedules are being followed. CDPOs may be encouraged to convey and support Supervisors and AWWs in delivery of in-centre care and home visit guidance.

d. Additional resource persons in the District may be identified to support and train AWWs, such as DIETs, nursery teacher training institutes, non-profit

organisations, private daycare centres, Balvatikas, other government or private pre-primary schools or teachers, interested and experienced individuals, community leaders etc.

5. For State WCD or Social Justice Departments:

a. The entire document may be considered as a model for State-level frameworks, to be provided to the Anganwadi system and creche functionaries.

b. Detailed monthly may be customized by the State for local culture, traditions, folk tales, stories, games, indigenous toys etc.

c. Customized and translated materials may be printed and provided in every Anganwadi centre, through DPOs, CDPOs and Supervisors.

d. During review meetings including in the Annual programme Implementation plan, quarterly review meetings of Mission Poshan 2.0 etc, it can be checked whether the monthly activities and Divyang screening schedules are being followed. CDPOs may be encouraged to convey and support Supervisors and AWWs in delivery of in-centre instruction.

e. Additional resource persons in the State may be identified and brought in to support with localization, and train AWWs, such as SCERTs, DIETs, Cluster Resource Centres of the School Education Department, National Institutes under DEPWD, nursery teacher training institutes, non-profit organizations, private daycare centres, Balvatikas, other government or private pre-primary schools or teachers, interested and experienced individuals, community leaders etc.

6. For Health, Tribal Affairs, and Persons with Disability Departments etc:

a. The document may be referred for convergence (such as referral and medical diagnosis of children with disabilities under Health Department, inclusion (for children with disabilities, linkage with Cross Disability Early Intervention Centres (CDEICs), National Institutes (NIs), provision of Swavlamban Card and assistive devices etc. under Department of Persons with Disabilities)

b. Additional resource persons in the State may be identified and brought in to support with localization, and train AWWs, such as SCERTs, DIETs, Cluster Resource Centres of the School Education Department, National Institutes under DEPWD, Nursery Teacher Training Institutes, Non-Profit Organizations, private daycare centres, Balvatikas, other government or private pre-primary schools or teachers, interested and experienced individuals, community leaders etc.

7. Other Institutions and Individuals:

a. The document may be used as ready reference for best practices in contextualized ECD delivery for children from birth to three years.

b. The material has been prepared specific to the Indian context, but may be explored and adapted for delivery in international contexts, particularly in the Global South.

c. It can be referred to by researchers, policy makers, early educators, curriculum designers, and even parents, for ideas on how to engage with their children.

MILESTONE MOMENTS

CHILDREN LEARN WHAT THEY EXPERIENCE

How your child plays, learns, speaks and acts offers important clues about your child's development. Check the milestones your child has reached at each age. Also learn what you need to do to help the child achieve these milestones.

Introduction

Research about brain development suggests that experiences during the first two years of life have a major impact on your child's future. Each time you play, talk, touch and respond to your child in a loving manner, you have made a significant difference. This chapter

is filled with important activities that the children do at each stage of development and what we need to do to benefit our children at each stage of development. This would also be a reminder to all parents, the importance of play activities.



"If you want your children to be intelligent, read them fairy tales. If you want them to be more intelligent, read them more fairy tales." - Albert Einstein



Birth to 2-3 Months

Talk with your baby's doctor at every visit about the milestones your child has reached and what to expect next.

What most babies do at this age?



- Begin to recognize the faces of the people at 8-12 inches away
- Prefer human faces and black and white contrast patterns
- Follow moving objects
- Pay close attention to and turn head towards the voice of the mother
- Begin to smile at people
- Startle or erupt into cry at loud noises
- Coo, make gurgling sounds when happy or after feeding
- Can hold head up and begin to push up when lying on tummy
- Make smooth movements with arms and legs
- Keep hands relaxed and take swipes at dangling objects
- Begin to babble



- Cuddle, talk, and play with your baby during feeding, dressing, and bathing
- Attend to cries immediately and hold the baby close to make her feel secure
- Help your baby learn to calm herself. It's okay for her to suck on her fingers
- Act excited and smile when your baby makes sounds
- Help your baby learn to calm herself
- Pay attention to your baby's different cries so that you learn to know what she wants
- Talk, read, and sing to your baby
- Lay your baby on his tummy when she is awake and keep toys near her

Contact ANM/AWW/health care provider immediately if you see any one of these "Warning" signs



No social smile



Does not make any eye contact when being fed, cuddled or spoken to



Persistent squinting after 2 months



Does not startle / wake up / cry in response to sudden loud sound



Head pushed back with stiff arms and legs



Hands are kept fisted or open with thumbs held persistently inside the palm

JOURNEY OF THE FIRST



105 MILESTONE MOMENTS

Birth to 2-3 Months

Learning through play & Age appropriate Toys



The traditional "jhoola" or "thooli" is essentially a U-shaped cloth hammock made from the mother's cotton sarees, traditionally used to put babies to sleep and gives the same posture which she was feeling in the mother's womb. This carries the smell of mother which makes the child relax.



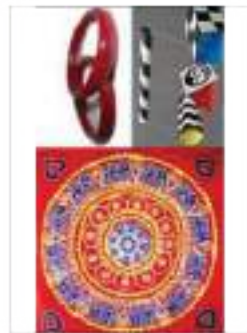
Babies enjoy looking at colorful objects and shapes and can see only up to 30 cm. So hang toys close to their face. At this stage of development Child begins to recognize the face of their mother.



Parents should talk to them and sing to them. Mother's should not use any body spray as this mask the mother's original smell which helps the baby to identify. Mother's hair style should not be changed as this helps the newborn to recognize her with his/her limited vision.



Shake a rattle, bell or a squeaky toy so that they familiarise with the source of sound and enjoy.



These red bangles, or black and white toys can be tied to a thread and dangled in front of the baby to help in visual fixation and tracking and to initiate reaching for the object. These colorful Pipal or Dhooli clothes are visually stimulating for children and can be hanging near the child at a distance of 40-50 cm from the child's face.

Your Baby at 4 - 6 Months: "The Looker"

Talk with your baby's doctor at every visit about the milestones your child has reached and what to expect next.

What most babies do at this age?



- Copy some movements and facial expressions, like smiling or frowning
- Like to look at self in a mirror & Reach for toy with one hand
- Attempt to reach and grasp a toy, using both hands and eyes together
- Follow moving things with eyes from side to side
- Keep head steady, unsupported, when held upright
- Can hold a toy and shake it & Bring hands to mouth
- Push up to elbows, when lying on tummy
- Smile spontaneously, especially at known people
- Like to play with familiar people and might cry when playing stops
- Begin to babble ('an, ee, oo, other than when crying), laughs aloud or makes squealing sounds
- Respond to affection and let you know if she is happy or sad



- Hold and talk to your baby. Smile and be cheerful while you do
- Show her a mirror and ask, "Where is my baby?"
- Set steady routines for sleeping and feeding
- Play games such as peek-a-boo
- Show her the pictures and name the objects but don't teach her the alphabet. Tell her stories.
- Babies learn by exploring objects in their homes. Put interesting and safe things on the floor for the baby to reach out and explore.
- Take children outdoors and introduce them to the outside world.
- Children suck on their fingers and thumb for comfort. It is not a cause for concern. Do not stop at this early age.
- Communicate with baby. Imitate baby sounds and praise her when she imitates yours.

Contact ANM/AWW/health care provider immediately if you see any one of these "Warning" signs



Lacks head control



Cannot sit up even with help



Does not grasp things within reach



Does not vocalize by making different sounds, such as ah, 'ee', 'oo'



Head and eyes do not move or track a moving object



Unable to raise head when on tummy

JOURNEY OF THE FIRST



108 MILESTONE MOMENTS

Your Baby at 4 - 6 Months: "The Looker"

Learning through play & Age appropriate Toys



Give your child unbreakable plastic mirrors attached to the inside of bed or hand held mirror at 6 month of age.



Play with soft balls including some that make soft, pleasant sounds.



Textured toys which can be prepared at home will help children understand the feel of various textures.



Babies can hold the rattle in their hands and can enjoy the sound by 4 months of age.

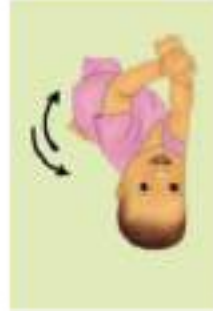


Give children small, rounded push toy like simple cars or animals on wheels / rollers (starting around 6 months).

Your Baby at 7 - 9 Months: "The Cruiser"

Talk with your baby's doctor at every visit about the milestones your child has reached and what to expect next.

What most babies do at this age?



- Roll over or turn over in both directions
- Grasp a toy by using all fingers
- Locate source of sound
- Turn head to visually follow familiar faces or toys
- Utter consonants sounds like 'p', 'b', 'm'; start babbling like "mamama" and "bababa"
- Looks for toys that have been hidden in front of them
- Respond to name being called
- Stretch arms to be picked up
- May be afraid of strangers
- Put things in mouth
- Move things smoothly from one hand to the other

Contact ANM/AWW/health care provider immediately if you see any one of these "Warning" signs



Cannot roll over



Needs support to sit



Does not turn towards a sound (out of sight)

What you should do?



- ❖ Let children drop, bang and throw things repeatedly
- ❖ Respond to the noise that the child makes in a gentle and patient manner
- ❖ Give your child clean, safe household utensils to play and explore
- ❖ Play games like peek-a-boo and hide-and-seek
- ❖ Hide a child's favorite toy under a cloth or box. See if the child can find it.
- ❖ Play games with "my turn, your turn"
- ❖ Teach cause-and-effect by rolling balls back and forth, pushing toy cars and trucks and putting blocks in and out of a container
- ❖ Read and talk to your baby



Does not utter pa..pa..pa..ma..ma..ba..ba, etc.



Tilts head to one side each time when looking at objects

JOURNEY OF THE FIRST



110 MILESTONE MOMENTS

Your Baby at 7 - 9 Months: "The Cruiser"

Learning through play & Age appropriate Toys



Peek-a-boo develops understanding for partially hidden objects. Babies will reach for an object that is partially hidden, indicating knowledge that the whole object is still there, if an object is completely hidden however the baby makes no attempt to retrieve it initially.



Let your child play with toys, in different sizes, shapes and colors, that can be stacked.



Use squeeze and squeak toys.



Give her interlocking plastic discs or a ring, and soft plastic rings for mouthing and teething.



Encourage the child to play with blocks and shapes.

Your Baby at 10 - 12 Months: "The Explorer"

Talk with your baby's doctor at every visit about the milestones your child has reached and what to expect next.

What most babies do at this age?



- Sit without support and reach for toys without falling
- Raise arms to be picked up
- Crawl to get desired toys without bumping into any objects
- Transfer object from one hand to another hand and bang two objects together
- Use one or two common words in mother tongue
- Say "mama" and "dada" and exclamations like "uh-oh!"
- Respond to simple requests like "no", "come here" etc.
- Cry when mom or dad leaves
- Show or hand you a book when she wants to hear a story
- Use simple gestures, like shaking head or waving "bye-bye"
- Find hidden things easily
- Copy gestures



- ❖ Place a toy slightly out of reach to encourage standing and walking while using support
- ❖ While exploring, babies might hurt others accidentally. Show them how to touch gently. Do not shout at them.
- ❖ Tell your baby stories and read picture books aloud.
- ❖ Babies are curious about everything. They are learning to choose what to want to play with. Help them in their exploration but ensure their safety.
- ❖ Babies learn by watching what their parents do and then trying to copy the same. This is how they learn.
- ❖ Babies drop bang and throw objects to see what happens next. Parents should remain patient and turn this into exploratory play.
- ❖ Show and name things in their environment

Contact ANM/AWW/health care provider immediately if you see any one of these "Warning" signs



Cannot pick small objects with finger and thumb

Does not stretch hands to be picked up

Does not respond to own name

Does not search for half hidden toys that the child sees you hide

Does not play social games like peek-a-boo (michaula/michauli)

JOURNEY OF THE FIRST



112 MILESTONE MOMENTS

Your Baby at 10 - 12 Months: "The Explorer"

Learning through play & Age appropriate Toys



Babies play and learn by exploring and touching objects at home. Avoid any sharp objects.



Toys that have finger, hands and legs; the rag doll prepared from cloth.



Push and pull toys specially at the age of 11-12 months.



Baby books or old magazines with bright pictures don't teach them alphabets but show only pictures and tell them stories.



Babies play with toys of different color, shapes, size and surfaces to learn and explore. They tend to repeatedly bring two toys together and then pull them apart as a part of the play. They tend to put one tumbler into another and learn about sizes and shapes. Textured toys can be also prepared at home, to make them realize the feel of various textures.

Your Baby at 13-18 Months: "The Walker"

Talk with your baby's doctor at every visit about the milestones your child has reached and what to expect next.

What most babies do at this age?

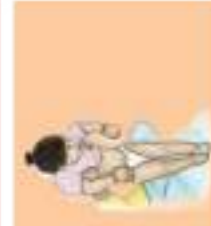


- ④ Can take several independent steps. Can walk alone.
- ④ Use many familiar gestures (like waving, clapping)
- ④ Put pebbles/small objects in a container
- ④ Name and identify common objects and their pictures in a book
- ④ Show interest in a doll or stuffed animal toy by pretending to feed
- ④ May have temper tantrums
- ④ Point to show someone what they want
- ④ Say several single words, at least 5 words consistently even if not clear
- ④ Say and shake head "no"
- ④ Know what ordinary things are for; for example, soap, glass, brush, spoon
- ④ Scribble on her own, spontaneously
- ④ Can follow 1-step verbal commands without any gestures, for example, sit when you say "sit down"
- ④ Drink from a cup or small glass
- ④ Eat with a spoon or own hands, though it may spill



- ❖ Provide push toy for babies to learn walking
- ❖ Give some fruits, toys, etc. to children. Ask them to identify the objects, put them in and take them out of containers
- ❖ Ask your child simple questions. Encourage them to talk.
- ❖ Provide a safe, loving environment. It's important to be consistent and predictable.
- ❖ Praise good behaviors more than you punish bad behaviors.
- ❖ Encourage empathy. For example, when the baby sees a sad, encourage her to hug or pat the other child.
- ❖ Read books and talk about the pictures using simple words.
- ❖ Provide toys that encourage pretend play, for example, dolls, play telephones.
- ❖ Encourage her to drink from a cup and use a spoon, no matter how messy.
- ❖ Blow bubbles and let your child pop them.

Contact ANM/AWW/health care provider immediately if you see any one of these "Warning" signs



Cannot stand on her own without support

Cannot put small objects in container

Does not point finger at an object when named

Does not respond to mother's gestures and seems to be in her own world

Does not use both hands for everyday activities (shows preference for one hand)

Does not say single words (like "mama" or "dada")

JOURNEY OF THE FIRST

270 Days

365 Days

1000 Days

Days

114 MILESTONE MOMENTS

Your Baby at 13-18 Months: "The Walker"

Learning through play & Age appropriate Toys



Toddlers learn by imitating. They need many opportunities to practice.



Introduce picture books but do not teach the alphabet yet.



Toddlers are very active. Keep them safe as they walk, run and climb. Children of this age are quite curious.



Toys for this age group should be safe and able to withstand a toddler's manipulation. Examples include: Cloth or plastic books with large pictures, Kid cars, Musical toys, Nesting blocks, Stacking toys.



Push-and-pull toys (without long cords)

Your Baby at 18 - 24 Months: "The Doer"

Talk with your baby's doctor at every visit about the milestones your child has reached and what to expect next.

What most babies do at this age?



- Can take several independent steps. Can walk alone.
- Walk steadily even while pulling the toy
- Imitate household chores / tasks.
- Correctly point out and name one or more body parts in person or in books.
- Begin to run and kick a ball
- Prefer to play along with other children but not necessarily playing with each other
- Show defiant behavior (doing what he has been told not to)
- Play near or close to other children, but not with each other.
- Point to things or pictures when they are named such as dog, cat and birds
- Say sentences by joining two words (like mama- dudhu (milk); mama-mam (water) etc.
- Copy action and words



- Provide opportunity for children to walk, run and climb safely.
- Allow children to imitate you and help them by providing opportunity to practice their skills.
- Be patient with them even if they make a mess.
- Encourage children to follow a daily routine, such as sleeping and making up, at a fixed time.
- Read aloud stories to your child often repeating them.
- Provide a copy and paper for the child to scribble.
- Encourage your child to help with simple chores at home, like sweeping and making dinner. Praise your child for being a good helper.
- At this age, children still play next to (not with) each other and don't share well. Give the children lots of toys to play with. Watch the children closely and step in if they fight or argue.
- Give your child attention and praise when he follows your instructions. Limit attention for defiant behavior. Spend a lot more time praising good behaviors than punishing for bad ones.
- Hide your child's toys around the room and let her find them.

Contact ANM/AWW/health care provider immediately if you see any one of these "Warning" signs



Does not walk steadily while pulling a toy



Cannot scribble



Does not use two word phrases such as "give milk"



Does not make appropriate response to gestures such as responding to bye-bye/namaste



Does not point to body parts



Does not seem to understand and follow simple instructions

JOURNEY OF THE FIRST



116 MILESTONE MOMENTS

Your Baby at 18 - 24 Months: "The Doer"

Learning through play & Age appropriate Toys



Children start matching objects with similar shape and size.



Kicking a ball. Learning to balance and anticipate while in motion.



Building blocks with cubes.



Social Toys



Learning to share and socialize. Children play in presence of other kids engaging in the same activity, yet not paying attention to each other

While play is essential one needs to know when to stop and give rest

Baby cues: 'I need a break or a change of activity'

If your baby turns her head away, arches her back or cries, s/he's telling you she needs a break or a change of activity. Try putting your baby on the floor to play or into bed if it's time for sleep.



Baby tired signs: 'I need rest'

If your baby is yawning, rubbing his eyes or jerking his arms or legs, he's showing tired signs. Toddlers and older babies might whimper, cry and demand attention. Try giving your child some quiet time in bed to help her settle to sleep.



Common Practices That Can Harm Your Baby

- ❖ Giving honey or 'Janam Ghutti' to a baby before 1 year of age
- ❖ Not giving breast milk for few days after birth
- ❖ Cow's milk – thinking it's light & sacred
- ❖ Over applying baby powder
- ❖ Giving a hard massage or giving a massage too often
- ❖ Trying to remove body hair using besan and atta (gram and "wheat flour)
- ❖ Applying 'surma' or 'kajal' to a newborn's eyes.
- ❖ It is best not to tie a black thread around your baby's wrist or neck. This can lead to choking, strangulation, infection in the skin. If need be, one can put a kaala teeka on the forehead or foot.
- ❖ Putting a few drops of oil in the ear and navel
- ❖ Leaving the child alone for short periods of time



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सत्यमेव जयते
Government of India